Leakage-Free Benchmarking of Classical Machine Learning and Graph Neural Networks for Low-Data TgDHFR Bioactivity Prediction

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ABSTRACT

Small bioactivity data sets invite optimistic results: test molecules leak into training, and the model that reports the score is the one chosen on it. We re-examined both on 859 curated inhibitors of *Toxoplasma gondii* dihydrofolate reductase (TgDHFR). Removing the leaks from the original study's code one at a time lowered its R^2 from 0.853 to 0.740, the level of a model with no feature selection; the largest was a feature importance computed on the test molecules. The same leak applied to a classical learner reproduced the reported gain, so the gain came from the protocol and not from the method.

Free of leakage, four classical representations and seven neural models were scored on the same 25 outer folds of a repeated nested cross-validation. Morgan-fingerprint ensembles reached $R^2 = 0.769 \pm 0.041$, and ten 3D shape descriptors added to the best descriptor set changed nothing. A Directed Message Passing Neural Network reached 0.725 by default and 0.726 after a nested search, below the fingerprint ensembles, though only narrowly after multiple-comparison correction. Only a network initialized from a pretrained foundation model caught up (0.761, equivalent in R^2 and MAE), at 8.2 times the cost; none exceeded it. Holding whole scaffolds out cost every model between 0.16 and 0.24 units of R^2. Repeated on 12 external targets, the comparison held on every one of them (mean advantage +0.092 R^2 for the classical ensemble), and on their published activity cliffs that advantage was larger, not smaller.

On an FDA-approved library the deployed model placed only 14 of 3056 scored compounds inside its applicability domain, so its top-ranked compounds are hypotheses, not leads. On this target, keeping the evaluation clean mattered more than making the model complex, and a fixed fingerprint ensemble was enough. The leak audit speaks for one implementation; the benchmark it motivated speaks for 12.

1. Introduction

1.1. Predictive Modeling in Low-Data Bioactivity Regimes

Quantitative structure–activity relationship (QSAR) modeling is constrained when few labeled compounds are available (Winkler, 2026). In that regime, simpler and more interpretable approaches, such as multivariate linear regression or classical tree-based ensembles, often match or exceed the predictive reliability of neural networks (Shalit Peleg and Milo, 2023; Xie et al., 2023). Relative to highly parameterized neural models, these learners impose stronger inductive constraints and tend to exhibit lower estimation variance in small-sample settings, so their performance depends less on which compounds happen to fall in the training split, particularly when they are given informative descriptors (Xie et al., 2023).

The counterpart of that stability is how readily small data sets are overfitted, a risk that grows as the number of molecular descriptors approaches or exceeds the number of compounds (Hawkins, 2004; Goodarzi et al., 2013). A common response is to enlarge the training set by data augmentation or synthetic sample generation (Gerz and Jelali,

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2026; Meyer et al., 2025), which adds computational cost (Calle et al., 2025) and, applied carelessly, obscures what the base algorithm achieves on its own. What matters most is where augmentation sits relative to partitioning: when copies are generated before the split, the "augment-then-split" fallacy, perturbed versions of a test molecule reach the training set, the partitions are no longer independent, and the reported metrics are inflated (Gerz and Jelali, 2026; John et al., 2025; Veetil et al., 2024). Augmentation therefore has to stay inside the training folds of a partition fixed beforehand (Gerz and Jelali, 2026; John et al., 2025).

Evaluation in this regime also requires separating model building from model assessment. Tuning hyperparameters on a small sample with a large search space biases the selection (Cawley and Talbot, 2010), so an architecture scored on the same data that chose it says little about its behavior on unseen compounds. Nested cross-validation, also termed double cross-validation, is the established way to decouple the two (Baumann and Baumann, 2014; Cawley and Talbot, 2010). An unbiased estimate nonetheless answers a restricted question: a random k-fold partition measures interpolation among structurally related compounds rather than extrapolation to new chemotypes (Király et al., 2022; Xiong et al., 2020), which is the regime in which a screening model is actually deployed.

A model fitted to few compounds can further attain a good score by chance correlation, and y-randomization is the standard empirical check. The response is permuted and the model refitted, so that a score close to the one obtained with the true responses points to chance correlation rather than to a learned relationship (Rücker et al., 2007). Rücker et al. prescribe more than permuting the response: the whole model-building procedure, descriptor selection included, should be repeated inside each randomization, and the result compared with models built on random descriptors (Rücker et al., 2007). Unbiased selection, scaffold-aware partitioning and chance-correlation controls together define the minimum evidence that a low-data QSAR result has to supply.

1.2. Domain-Engineered Features versus End-to-End Representation Learning

Feature-based machine learning relies on domain-engineered descriptors and molecular fingerprints (Das et al., 2026). Morgan fingerprints of radius 2, the usual computational approximation to the extended-connectivity fingerprint ECFP4, encode local substructures, while physicochemical and 3D descriptors quantify specific molecular properties; both are computed deterministically and need no large training corpus (Bansal et al., 2025; Iwuala et al., 2026; Xie et al., 2023). Their drawback is dimensionality: accumulating handcrafted features produces large and redundant matrices (Goodarzi et al., 2013; Shalit Peleg and Milo, 2023), which on restricted data sets raises computational cost and makes feature selection itself a source of error (Goodarzi et al., 2013; Shalit Peleg and Milo, 2023).

End-to-end representation learning avoids manual feature engineering. Graph neural networks (GNNs) map molecular topologies into continuous latent spaces and model nonlinear interactions without a predefined descriptor set (Azad, 2026; Das et al., 2026), chemical language processing (CLP) applies the same idea to string representations such as SMILES (Özçelik and Grisoni, 2024), and generative architectures, among them variational autoencoders and generative adversarial networks, learn to sample from those spaces rather than to predict from them (Liu et al., 2023). The latter distinction matters here because synthetic sample generation is itself the augmentation strategy under evaluation: in the sparse, discrete space of SMILES strings a single altered character can yield an invalid structure (Liu et al., 2023), so the quality of the generated molecules, and not only the capacity of the predictor, conditions what augmentation can contribute.

How much this flexibility is worth when labels are scarce remains unsettled. Representation learning needs enough examples to recover what a descriptor encodes by construction, which makes it less effective as the labeled set shrinks (Konstantakos et al., 2025). The boundary is nonetheless moving (Dalmau et al., 2025): regularized nonlinear algorithms combined with structured linear priors reach results comparable to classical methods (Dalmau et al., 2025; Dar et al., 2023), and fine-tuning pretrained networks such as ChemBERTa has produced usable predictions from a few dozen labeled compounds (Oulladji et al., 2025; Espley et al., 2023). Classical ensembles, for their part, are reported to match or exceed deep architectures when data are scarce (Iwuala et al., 2026; Shalit Peleg and Milo, 2023; Das et al., 2026; Dar et al., 2023; Espley et al., 2023; Xie et al., 2023), although such comparisons are rarely run on identical, leakage-free folds.

For inhibitors of *Toxoplasma gondii* dihydrofolate reductase (TgDHFR), Karimova and Senanayake (2025) addressed the scarcity of labels with Gaussian noise-based data augmentation and ensembles of deep neural networks, raising their baseline R^2 from 0.75 to 0.85, and released both the curated data set and the code that produced it. Their result frames the operational question this study takes up: whether learned molecular representations outperform fixed Morgan fingerprints, and whether synthetic data generation is necessary at all for predictive reliability, once every model is scored on identical, leakage-free outer folds.

1.3. Data Leakage in Low-Data Molecular Modeling

Data leakage, the entry of test-set information into the training process, inflates performance estimates without producing an error or a warning (Vrba et al., 2026; Gerz and Jelali, 2026). The term covers mechanisms that differ in where independence is lost, and the distinction matters because each leaves a different trace and calls for a different remedy. We therefore separate four sources and quantify each one independently in the published pipeline: transformation leakage, selection leakage, partition contamination and structural overlap.

Transformation leakage occurs in preprocessing: when scaling, imputation or variance-based filtering is fitted on the complete data set, the model is given information about the distribution of the test compounds, the independence of the partitions is lost, and the resulting estimate is optimistic (Correa et al., 2025; Lewis et al., 2023). Selection leakage occurs whenever the test partition guides a choice about the model: a validation set that repeatedly informs hyperparameters, an early-stopping criterion read off the test set, or a feature importance computed in sample. A partition used that way stops being independent of the model, and highly parameterized architectures such as deep neural networks are the best placed to exploit the overlap, fitting noise and returning optimistic estimates of the generalization error (Baumann and Baumann, 2014; Konstantakos et al., 2025).

The remaining two sources concern the composition of the partitions rather than what is fitted on them. Partition contamination arises when the split is redrawn after synthetic copies have been generated, so that a perturbation of a test molecule can train the model (Gerz and Jelali, 2026; John et al., 2025). Structural overlap arises when the same canonical structure, often duplicated under different database identifiers, appears on both sides of a split that is nominally disjoint. The first two sources are closed by fitting every transformation and every selection step inside the training partition at hand; the last two require the partition itself to be defined over distinct structures and held fixed thereafter. Incomplete reporting of data partitioning can therefore cause gains produced by leakage to be attributed incorrectly to model architecture (Rojas and Madanian, 2026).

1.4. Scope and Contributions

This study asks whether, on one small and well-characterized bioactivity set (859 TgDHFR inhibitors), graph networks, 3D descriptors, feature selection and data augmentation improve on classical ensembles trained on fingerprints once the evaluation is free of leakage. We do not assume the answer: every model is scored on the same leakage-free outer folds, and the comparison is designed so that either outcome would be detectable. The conclusions are then checked against chance correlation, scaffold-grouped splits and the curation decision. On that basis we contribute:

- **A quantitative audit of four leakage mechanisms.** Four ways in which information about the test molecules reaches a model in low-data molecular machine learning—re-partitioning after augmentation, early stopping on the test set, feature importance computed in sample, and duplicate structures—are removed one at a time from a published pipeline, so that the contribution of each to the reported R^2 is measured rather than asserted.
- **The reported gain, reproduced as an artifact.** The feature selection and Gaussian-noise augmentation that took the original R^2 from 0.75 to 0.85 do not improve a classical learner under the same hold-out protocol, but the same selection performed leakily on that learner reproduces the improvement, so the gain measures the leak and not the intervention.
- **A leakage-free comparison with equivalence testing.** Four representation spaces are compared against seven neural models, from a default Chemprop D-MPNN to a pretrained foundation model and the original architecture rebuilt without its leaks, on identical folds and with their measured computational cost. A pretrained model is the only network that reaches equivalence with the fingerprint ensemble.

The final model is also applied to a library of approved drugs, which locates the candidates it ranks highest with respect to its applicability domain. Those candidates are computational hypotheses, and the study as a whole is a target-specific methodological benchmark rather than evidence that one model family is universally superior.

2. Materials and Methods

Figure 1 summarizes the audit, the benchmark, the robustness analyses and the virtual-screening application.

2.1. Bioactivity Benchmark Dataset and Curation

This study uses the published benchmark of *Toxoplasma gondii* dihydrofolate reductase (TgDHFR) inhibitors compiled by Karimova and Senanayake (Karimova and Senanayake, 2025), taken as released, after their curation. Working on their data rather than on a set of our own keeps the comparison with their results on one protocol and one object, so that a difference in score cannot be attributed to a difference in curation. The primary benchmark uses no synthetic augmentation, which leaves the measured performance attributable to the algorithms and to the empirical measurements alone.

The curation inherited from the original study merged drug–protein interaction parameters and SMILES structures from BindingDB with bioactivity data from ChEMBL, standardized the structures by salt stripping and structural validation, and resolved compounds measured more than once: assays whose bioactivity varied by more than 1.5 log units were discarded by the interquartile-range rule and the remaining values averaged into one measurement per ligand (Karimova and Senanayake, 2025). None of those steps was repeated here. The released table, file `1-Training_Database/V2-combined_bd_chmbl_unique.csv` of the authors' repository, contains 875 records, and the copy used here is identical to it.

Two decisions were taken on top of it, and both are ours. The first is an exclusion rule for extreme potencies, specified before any model was fitted: Tukey's rule on the pIC_{50} distribution (fences at $\mathrm{Q1} - 1.5\,\mathrm{IQR} = 2.06$ and $\mathrm{Q3} + 1.5\,\mathrm{IQR} = 10.80$) places 2 records outside the fences, a classical antifolate analogue at $pIC_{50} = 11.68$ and a practically inactive compound at $pIC_{50} = 1.56$, which leaves 873 entries. Because an exclusion of this kind can itself shape the reported performance, every conclusion of this study was also re-derived in a separate execution of the complete benchmark that keeps the two records (Section 3.6).

The second decision is structural deduplication, which the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) principles for QSAR validation require (Tropsha, 2010; Cherkasov et al., 2013; Iwuala et al., 2025) and without which the same molecule can train and test a model. All SMILES were canonicalized with RDKit, and the 873 entries turned out to describe only 859 distinct structures: 14 molecules appeared twice under different PubChem CIDs, and the second occurrence of each was removed. The measured pIC_{50} values within each pair differed by at most 0.18 units, so the target distribution is practically unchanged. The removed records are listed in `data/V2-combined_bd_chmbl_unique_duplicates.csv`.

Two benchmarks follow from those decisions and are kept distinct throughout. The *primary benchmark* comprises the 859 unique structures that remain once the two extreme-potency records are excluded, and carries every result reported below unless stated otherwise. The *sensitivity benchmark* comprises the 861 unique structures obtained when those two records are retained, and is used in Section 3.6 alone. The target is pIC_{50} ($-\log_{10}(IC_{50})$) (Karimova and Senanayake, 2025); the logarithmic transformation places potency measurements on the conventional and more numerically tractable scale for regression.

2.2. Classical Replication of the Published Interventions

To quantify what the interventions reported in the original study contribute, its hold-out protocol was replicated in an isolated ablation. A 15% hold-out partition was separated first (seed 42), and everything below was learned from the development partition only. The baseline (A) is the stacking ensemble on all 2048 Morgan bits. The feature-selection variant (B) computes the permutation importance of every bit on the development partition (5 repeats, negative mean squared error) and keeps the bits whose mean importance is positive beyond floating-point noise (greater than 10^{-9}), because bits that the model never uses have an importance that is zero up to rounding error. The augmentation variant (C) adds, to the selected features, perturbation of the training features via additive Gaussian noise: applying the two noise levels of the published code ($\sigma = 0.01$ and $\sigma = 0.001$, which that code introduces as a factor to be adjusted to the scale of the data and does not otherwise justify) generated two synthetic variants per original molecule, which triplicated the training space (to 2190 rows) with the held-out molecules left untouched. Each variant is the average of five stacking ensembles that differ in the seed of their tree models.

The leak that the original selection contains was also measured on this classical replication, where it needs no deep network. Variant B computes its permutation importance on the development partition alone. A second version of it, identical except that the importance is computed on the complete data set as the original study does, was fitted and scored on the same held-out molecules, and the two sets of selected bits were compared by their Jaccard index. Variant C was treated in the same way.

2.3. Audit of the Original Pipeline

The comparison above treats the figures of the original study as given. To establish what produces them, its published code was obtained and run in its original TensorFlow environment before anything was changed, which fixes the object of the audit as the pipeline as published rather than a reimplementation of it. Because one run of a stochastic pipeline carries its own variability, every stage was then repeated over 10 random seeds.

The pipeline was then taken apart one mechanism at a time. Each of the four mechanisms below is a property of the published code, verifiable by reading it; what the audit establishes is therefore not whether a mechanism is present, but how much of the reported R^2 it accounts for. Starting from the published protocol (R0), four modifications were applied in sequence, each closing one path by which information about the test molecules reaches the fitted model: (R1) the synthetic copies produced by Gaussian augmentation are no longer re-partitioned after augmentation, so a perturbed copy of a test molecule can no longer train the model; (R2) early stopping and model choice use an internal split of the training partition instead of the test set; (R3) the permutation importance that drives feature selection is computed out of fold inside the training rows instead of on the test molecules; and (R4) structures that occur more than once are removed from both sides of the split. Every rung was run over 10 random seeds.

Each rung alters only the mechanism it names. What follows from that alteration—how many bits the selection retains, and which molecules remain evaluable once duplicate structures are removed—is a consequence of it and is reported as such, not a further change to the protocol.

The ladder therefore yields two quantities that are not of the same kind, and they are reported differently. The differences between rungs R1 to R4 are paired: those rungs share the 130 molecules common to all of them, so each difference estimates the effect of closing one path on one fixed set of test molecules, and a percentile bootstrap over those molecules gives its confidence interval. The difference between R0 and R1 is not paired, because the published protocol builds its own evaluation partition by re-splitting the augmented data and therefore shares no test molecules with the rungs below it; that difference estimates the gap between the performance the published protocol reports and the performance of the same pipeline without the re-split, and is summarized over seeds rather than over molecules. A reference model with no feature selection of any kind was fitted on the same clean split.

2.4. Representation Spaces: Molecular Fingerprints and Conformational Descriptors

We generated four distinct molecular representation spaces using RDKit (Landrum et al., 2025) to systematically map the structure-activity relationship. The structural baseline relied on Morgan fingerprints (ECFP4). We computed these with a radius of 2 and folded them into a fixed-length vector of 2048 bits. Extended-connectivity fingerprints offer rapid calculation and capture a vast array of distinct local substructural features (Rogers and Hahn, 2010); chirality was not encoded. Classical 2D fingerprint-based models frequently achieve predictive parity with state-of-the-art 3D structure-based models when relying exclusively on ligand information (Gao et al., 2020).

To establish a physicochemical baseline, the pipeline extracted every two-dimensional topological and physicochemical descriptor that RDKit 2025.9.3 exposes, taken from `Descriptors._descList` in the order that module defines, with no manual exclusion: 217 descriptors for this version. Curated 2D molecular representations demonstrate substantial robustness; recent studies confirm they maintain scaffold-independent advantages over 3D alternatives across various property prediction tasks (Tiwari et al., 2026). A third hybrid space concatenated these 217 descriptors with the 2048-bit Morgan fingerprints to evaluate potential synergistic effects.

A fourth representation appended ten 3D shape descriptors (asphericity, eccentricity, inertial shape factor, the two normalized principal moment ratios, the three principal moments of inertia, radius of gyration, and spherocity index) to this hybrid, for 2275 features in total, to assess the predictive value of spatial geometry. Hydrogens were added and a single conformer per molecule was generated with the Experimental-Torsion Knowledge Distance Geometry algorithm (ETKDGv3, fixed random seed of 42, random initial coordinates as a fallback) (Riniker and Landrum, 2015). One conformer, rather than an ensemble, is what tabular QSAR benchmarks of this kind commonly use, and it keeps the cost of the 3D space comparable to that of the others; the ten descriptors are shape summaries of that single geometry, so what this representation tests is whether such a summary adds information, not whether a conformational ensemble would (Section 4). Because purely distance-based constraints often distort aromatic rings and sp^2 centers, ETKDGv3 integrates experimental torsion-angle preferences derived from small-molecule crystallographic data. The conformer was then locally minimized with the MMFF94 force field before descriptor extraction. Conformer embedding failed for 0 of the 859 molecules, and 0 descriptor values of the 2D+3D+FP matrix were missing or infinite before imputation.

Although integrating spatial information remains critical for molecular image-based modeling (Matsuzaka and Uesawa, 2023) and geometry-augmented representation learning (Zhang and Bai, 2024), recent empirical evaluations

suggest that 3D conformer descriptors yield limited incremental predictive value over curated 2D representations in standard tabular benchmarks (Tiwari et al., 2026). Including the 3D space here tests that suggestion on this target rather than assuming it.

No variance-based filtering was applied to any representation: a descriptor that is constant is simply never used by a tree-based learner, and the scaler leaves it at zero. Imputation by the median, standardization and feature selection are instead steps of one scikit-learn pipeline, so all three are fitted inside each training partition and never see the fold they are scored on. The four spaces were evaluated under the identical protocol of Section 2.5; which of them the deployed model uses was decided afterwards, on cost, among those found equivalent (Section 3.2).

2.5. Nested Cross-Validation Protocol and Variance Correction

Model building and model assessment were separated by a 5×5 repeated nested cross-validation with random seed 42: a 5-fold outer loop repeated 5 times, giving 25 outer evaluations, with a 5-fold inner loop repeated 5 times inside each outer training partition (Krstajic et al., 2014; Cawley and Talbot, 2010). Methodological frameworks do not require the two loops to use the same number of folds (Krstajic et al., 2014), and a systematic comparison of validation schemes finds no uniformly superior variant, its ranking depending on the algorithm, the data and the circumstances of the study (Héberger, 2023). The same outer partitions were used for every representation and every model, so that all comparisons reported here are paired. Figure 2 shows one outer fold of this protocol.

Random splitting was adopted for the main benchmark. The objective is interpolation within the applicability domain of known TgDHFR inhibitors rather than extrapolation to new chemotypes, and at this sample size ($N = 859$) scaffold-based partitioning produces imbalanced folds from which whole bioactivity ranges can disappear (Király et al., 2022). Because random splits are optimistic for series of close analogs (Yang et al., 2019; Basit Iqbal et al., 2025), the Morgan-fingerprint ensemble and the D-MPNN were also run under scaffold-grouped splits. The Bemis-Murcko scaffold of each compound, without stereochemistry, defined a group; the 859 compounds fall into 262 groups, the largest with 49 members and 159 containing a single compound. In each of the 5 repeats, groups were visited in random order and each was assigned to the currently smallest of the 5 folds, so that no scaffold appears on both sides of an outer split. Everything else was identical to the random-split protocol, and both model families again shared the same folds.

That rule balances the size of the folds but not the response, and the resulting folds show it: across the 25 scaffold folds the number of test compounds ranges from 165 to 189, while their mean pIC_{50} ranges from 5.89 to 6.94, a spread of about one log unit. Stratifying the folds by the response would narrow that spread, but it would also use the variable being predicted to build the partition, which is the coupling this study sets out to avoid, and it would weaken the purpose of the design: a model facing an unfamiliar scaffold in practice also faces whatever potency range that scaffold happens to occupy. The heterogeneity is therefore reported rather than removed, and the drop in performance under these folds is to be read as including it.

The inner loop selected the architecture and, at the same time, confined every data-dependent transformation to the partition it was fitted on. Within each outer training pool it evaluated all 41 single, pairwise and three-way combinations of six regressor families ($\binom{6}{1} + \binom{6}{2} + \binom{6}{3} = 6 + 15 + 20$; combinations of four or more members were not considered, so that the search stays affordable inside every fold) (Random Forest, Extra Trees, LightGBM, XGBoost, SVR with an RBF kernel and $C = 10$, and k-nearest neighbours with $k = 5$ and cosine distance; the tree ensembles used 200 trees) and kept the combination with the highest mean inner-fold R^2. All hyperparameters were fixed in advance, so the inner loop selects among architectures only; multi-model combinations were combined by a `StackingRegressor` with a `RidgeCV` meta-estimator trained on 5-fold out-of-fold base predictions. Fitting a global transformation before partitioning would leak data-set-wide statistics into the training phase (Cawley and Talbot, 2010; Varma and Simon, 2006), so imputation, standardization and supervised feature selection were implemented as steps of the model pipeline and their parameters estimated only on the training partition at hand, an inner training fold during selection and the outer training pool for the final fit, then applied to the held-out data without re-estimation (Vrba et al., 2026). For the continuous descriptor spaces that pipeline chained median imputation, `StandardScaler` and `SelectFromModel` keeping every descriptor with a strictly positive Random Forest importance; the binary Morgan space was passed to the regressors unchanged. The selected combination was refit on the whole outer training pool and scored once on the held-out outer fold. Predictions were clipped to the range of the training responses extended by 3 pIC_{50} units in either direction. The safeguard exists because a descriptor far outside the training range can pass through a power transform and produce a prediction of implausible magnitude, which a mean squared error reports as a collapse of the model; it binds only in that situation, and the bound is wide enough that an ordinary prediction never reaches it. Across the

25 outer folds of the four representations, 0 predictions were clipped, so no result reported for the classical models depends on the safeguard.

Repeated cross-validation violates the independence assumption of standard parametric tests, because its training sets overlap across iterations. Every comparison between models was therefore made on the shared outer folds with the Nadeau–Bengio corrected paired t-test (Nadeau and Bengio, 2003), which inflates the variance of the mean difference over the $J = 25$ outer folds from $\hat{\sigma}^2/J$ to $(1/J + n_{test}/n_{train})\,\hat{\sigma}^2$, with $n_{test}/n_{train} = 1/4$ for the 5-fold outer loop; p values within each family of comparisons were then adjusted by Holm's step-down procedure (Holm, 1979). Because a non-significant difference is not evidence that two models perform alike, each comparison was additionally submitted to two one-sided tests (Schuirmann, 1987) against an equivalence margin, equivalence being declared only when the 90% confidence interval of the difference lies entirely inside it. The two margins happen to coincide numerically at ± 0.05, but they are not the same quantity and were set for different reasons. For R^2, 0.05 is about a quarter of the spread between the best and the worst representation of this benchmark, so a difference below it cannot change which representation one would deploy. For MAE it is 0.05 pIC_{50} units, roughly a tenth of the experimental spread of the target and well inside the variation between assays that the curation of Section 2.1 tolerates, so a difference below it is smaller than the noise of the measurements being predicted. Neither margin comes from a standard, because the literature offers none, and neither was fixed before the data were seen: both were chosen while analyzing them, and a wider margin would make equivalence easier to declare. Every confidence interval needed to re-read these comparisons against a different margin is reported with them. Confidence intervals for the hold-out ablation of Section 3.2 come instead from 2000 percentile bootstrap resamples of the held-out molecules (Efron and Tibshirani, 1993); the resampled indices depend only on the seed, so the same molecules are drawn for every model and the differences are paired.

2.6. Neural Baselines and Graph-Model Variants

Benchmarking classical machine learning ensembles against advanced representation learning required implementing a Directed Message Passing Neural Network (D-MPNN) via the Chemprop framework (version 2.2.4) (Graff et al., 2026; Yang et al., 2019). To guarantee methodological parity, the D-MPNN was evaluated on the same 25 outer partitions (5×5 repeated cross-validation, random seed 42) used for the classical baselines, with each molecule predicted by a model that never saw it. Two variants were run: a default configuration, which needs no model selection, and a tuned variant whose hyperparameters were chosen by a hold-out search nested within each outer training partition, so that no held-out molecule took part in the selection. This alignment keeps the performance metrics directly comparable and removes the variance of a single split.

The architecture processes molecular SMILES strings by mapping them into graph representations, designating atoms as vertices and bonds as edges (Heid et al., 2023). Initial feature vectors capturing atomic identity and topological connectivity were constructed using `SimpleMoleculeMolGraphFeaturizer()`. The network applied `BondMessagePassing()` (hidden size 300, depth 3, no dropout) to extract embeddings directly from directed edges rather than vertices. A `MeanAggregation()` function pooled these atomic embeddings into a unified molecular vector.

Within each training partition, the continuous pIC_{50} targets were standardized with the training mean and standard deviation, and predictions were transformed back to the original scale. The pooled vector was batch-normalized and fed into a `RegressionFFN()` (one hidden layer of 300 units) to yield the final predictive output. The mean squared error on the standardized targets was the training loss. Model weights were optimized via PyTorch Lightning for a fixed number of 100 epochs on CPU, using Chemprop's default learning-rate schedule (2 warm-up epochs, initial rate 10^{-4}, peak 10^{-3}, final 10^{-4}) and a per-fold random seed (42 plus the fold index). No early stopping or checkpoint selection was applied, so the model after the last epoch was used and the held-out fold never influenced training.

Unlike the classical ensembles, whose architecture was selected by an inner search, the default D-MPNN used Chemprop's default hyperparameters (hidden size 300, depth 3, no dropout); matching the classical search would require 1025 trainings per outer fold (41 combinations across 5 inner splits repeated 5 times), which at the measured cost of a single training is not feasible (Section 3.3), so the tuned variant uses a reduced search instead.

The tuned variant searched a grid of 8 configurations (hidden size 300 or 600, message-passing depth 3 or 5, dropout 0 or 0.2; the default configuration is one of them). Inside each outer training pool, 20% of the compounds were held out at random, every configuration was trained on the remaining 80% and the one with the lowest root-mean-square error on the held-out part was retained. That configuration was then retrained on the whole outer training pool, with the same 100-epoch schedule and per-fold seed, and scored once on the outer test fold. The held-out outer fold therefore played no role in the choice. The search is deliberately smaller than the classical one (a single inner split instead of 5 folds, and 8 configurations instead of 41 combinations), so it tests whether a moderate amount of tuning helps rather

than the best result that exhaustive tuning could reach. The default variant separates the inductive bias of the graph architecture from the effect of tuning on a small sample (Cawley and Talbot, 2010; Shalit Peleg and Milo, 2023), and the tuned variant checks whether that choice handicapped the network.

The default and the tuned variant both test one architecture on a modest budget. To separate what the graph architecture contributes from what the training budget and external data contribute, four further neural models were evaluated on the same 25 outer folds, each fitted on the outer training partition alone and scored exactly like the models above. The first is a feed-forward network on the same 2048-bit ECFP4 fingerprints used by the classical ensembles, which keeps their input and learns its own transformation of it. The second concatenates the vector learned by the D-MPNN with the RDKit 2D descriptors before the feed-forward head, so that the network receives the descriptor block as well. The third averages the predictions of 5 D-MPNN that differ only in their random seed, which buys accuracy with computation alone. The fourth initializes the message-passing weights from CheMeleon (Burns et al., 2025), a model pretrained to predict classical molecular descriptors for a large unlabeled corpus, and is the only model in this study that sees information from outside the benchmark. Its message-passing block is instantiated with the hyperparameters stored in the released checkpoint and loaded with its weights, while the regression head is initialized at random; no parameter is frozen, so the pretrained block is fine-tuned together with the head under the same 100-epoch schedule as the other graph models. CheMeleon also requires its own atom features (`MultiHotAtomFeaturizer.v2()`), so this model differs from the D-MPNN variants in initialization and in featurization, and the comparison between them should be read accordingly. None of the four was tuned.

Finally, the architecture of the original study was re-evaluated without its leaks on the same 25 outer folds, in two variants: the deep ensemble on all descriptors (DNN baseline) and the complete original pipeline of importance-based selection and Gaussian augmentation (DNN full), both with the selection and the augmentation confined to each training partition and with early stopping on an internal split. This separates what the architecture contributes from what the protocol contributes, and places the original model on the same folds as every other model in this study.

2.7. External Replication Across Twelve Bioactivity Targets

Everything described so far measures one target. A comparison between model families on 859 molecules of TgDHFR supports a statement about TgDHFR, not about the regime of a few hundred labeled molecules in general, and the leak-by-leak audit of Section 2.3 is tied to one published pipeline. The comparison was therefore repeated, unchanged, on an external collection: the MoleculeACE benchmark (van Tilborg et al., 2022), which distributes curated bioactivity sets together with a published partition and a per-compound activity-cliff flag for each of them. Every target of at most 1000 compounds was taken, which gives 12 targets of 615 to 976 compounds (9 measured as K_i and 3 as EC_{50}) spanning kinases, nuclear receptors and G-protein-coupled receptors, with the fraction of compounds flagged as activity cliffs ranging from 7 % to 48 %. That cap is a deliberate restriction to the sample size this study is about rather than a random draw from the collection: its larger sets were left out, so these targets can confirm or refute the result in the small-sample regime and say nothing about where the balance moves with more data.

Each target was run through the same two steps as the main benchmark, with the same code: the nested cross-validation of the classical ensembles over 2 representations (Morgan fingerprints and RDKit 2D descriptors) and the default D-MPNN, both on the same outer folds within each target, so that every comparison reported for a target is paired. The outer loop was 5-fold with 1 repeat, 5 outer folds per target, against the 5×5 of the main analysis. The reduction is a cost decision: 12 targets at 5 repeats would take weeks at the per-fold cost measured in Section 3.3. What it costs is precision within a target, and the per-target intervals are correspondingly wider than those of the main benchmark; what it does not touch is the comparison across targets, whose replicates are the targets themselves rather than the folds.

Each target was additionally scored once on the partition published with the collection, fitting both families on its training part and predicting its test part. This is the only comparison in this study that can be placed beside the numbers reported by the authors of the benchmark, because it uses their split and not ours. Those test parts hold 126 to 197 compounds, of which 13 to 91 carry the collection's activity-cliff flag, and the error was recorded three times: on the whole test part, on the flagged compounds alone, and on the remainder. The flags are the ones distributed with the benchmark and were not recomputed, so that subset is defined exactly as in the work that introduced it. The flagged subsets are small, the smallest of them 13 compounds, so a single target's cliff estimate is imprecise and only their summary across targets is interpreted.

The two families do not receive the same search effort in this cohort: the classical side selects its architecture inside every outer training partition, while the D-MPNN runs at Chemprop's defaults. That asymmetry is the price of

running 12 targets, and it is declared rather than argued away, together with the two measurements that bound it. On TgDHFR, the hold-out search of Section 2.6 moved the R^2 difference between the network and the Morgan ensemble from -0.044 to -0.043, leaving it essentially where it was. Within the cohort, that same search was run on the 2 targets where the default network falls furthest behind. Reporting differences as the classical value minus the neural one, so that a positive number always favours the classical model, the advantage moved from +0.209 to +0.200 on CLK4 and from +0.111 to +0.088 on GHSR. The remaining targets were not tuned, so what this cohort measures is a default graph network; the two that were tuned are those where tuning had the most room to change the conclusion.

Within each target, the comparison between the two families is the paired procedure of Section 2.5: the Nadeau–Bengio corrected t-test with Holm's adjustment, and the two one-sided equivalence tests against the same margins. Across targets the unit of analysis changes. Each target contributes one difference between the families, and those 12 differences were submitted to a two-sided one-sample t-test and to the exact Wilcoxon signed-rank test against zero, reported with a 95 % t interval. The four summaries built this way, the cross-validated cohort and the published split on its whole test part, on its cliffs and on its remainder, are four views of the same 12 differences rather than independent tests; they are reported together without an adjustment for multiplicity and are to be read as one result rather than as four.

2.8. Application: Screening within the Applicability Domain

The feature-selected Morgan-fingerprint stacking ensemble of the ablation above (Random Forest, XGBoost and SVR combined by a ridge meta-learner, trained without augmentation on the 730-compound development partition of the 15% hold-out split; hold-out $R^2 = 0.748$) was applied to a library of FDA-approved compounds ($N = 3378$). Two properties of this deployment are worth stating, since neither is visible from the result. The architecture was not chosen on the hold-out: RF+XGB+SVM is the combination that the nested selection of Section 2.5 retained in 76.0% of the 25 outer folds of the Morgan space, and the hold-out only estimates the model that this architecture yields, on molecules that took no part in building it. The ensemble was also not refitted on the complete 859-compound set, although the 129 additional compounds would be expected to help: a refitted model would have no estimate of its accuracy on data it had never seen, so the model applied here is the one whose hold-out R^2 is reported, and is if anything conservative with respect to what all the data would give. Structural pre-filtering kept only compounds containing H, C, N, O, F, P, S, Cl, Br and I, a set that covers all but 0 of the training compounds, and a size ceiling (molecular weight $\leq$ 1000 Da; the largest training compound weighs 594 Da) removed molecules whose potency the model could not meaningfully extrapolate.

Prediction on a library of this kind is only meaningful where the model has support. Following the finding of Sheridan et al. that prediction error grows as a molecule becomes less similar to the training set (Sheridan et al., 2004), every FDA compound was given its mean Tanimoto similarity (2048-bit Morgan fingerprints) to its 5 most similar training compounds, and was flagged as inside the applicability domain when this value was at least 0.638. The criterion of Sahigara et al. (2012) is a limit on distance, and the training compounds define it among themselves: the mean of their distances to their 5 nearest neighbours, taken as $1-$ Tanimoto similarity, plus 0.5 standard deviations. The threshold reported here is one minus that limit, so that it reads on the same similarity scale as the values it is compared with. Its reference set is the complete 859-compound training file, which is wider than the 730 compounds the deployed ensemble was fitted on. The multiplier is an arbitrary choice: the literature offers no universal rule, and a comparison of applicability-domain methods concludes that the appropriate one has to be determined for the data set at hand (Héberger, 2023). For that reason no compound was excluded on this flag, which is reported with every candidate, and the number of compounds the domain admits under every rule available for it is reported in the Supplementary Material (Table S10): the rules differ by more than a factor of two in the similarity they demand, and they place between 13 and 32 of the 3056 screened structures inside the domain, so the conclusion drawn from this flag does not rest on the multiplier.

Each predicted potency is reported with a prediction interval of ± 0.99 pIC_{50} units. The interval is the split-conformal half-width (Lei et al., 2018) obtained from the absolute residuals of this same ensemble on the 129 compounds of the hold-out partition, which took no part in fitting it or in choosing its architecture; it therefore covers the potency of a new compound with probability at least 90 %. That guarantee is marginal and not conditional: it holds on average over compounds exchangeable with the held-out ones, and does not widen for a compound outside the applicability domain, where it should be read as a lower bound on the uncertainty rather than as a measure of it.

Candidates were ranked by predicted potency alone, and no composite priority score was built: any weighting of potency against similarity would need coefficients that the data cannot fix, which is the same objection the threshold

above already carries. What the ranking is read against is reported instead of folded into it. Every candidate carries its similarity to the training set, its domain flag, its prediction interval and whether its structure belongs to the training data, so that a reader can separate a fitted value from an extrapolation without recomputing anything. Four ligand efficiency metrics were computed from the prediction and reported beside it, to show how much of a predicted potency is accounted for by molecular size (Hopkins et al., 2004, 2014); none of them was used as a filter, and their definitions and the assumptions they carry are given in the Supplementary Material. The ranked candidates were then submitted to an orthogonal structure-based check with AutoDock Vina against the TgDHFR crystal structure 6AOG (Trott and Olson, 2010; wwPDB consortium, 2019), whose protocol, validated by re-docking the co-crystallized ligand to a heavy-atom RMSD of 1.11 Å, is described in the Supplementary Material together with the consensus thresholds.

This stage generates computational hypotheses. None of the candidates was tested experimentally, and selectivity against human DHFR, which the antifolates among them are known to inhibit, was not assessed.

2.9. Computational Environment and Reproducibility

To support algorithmic transparency and computational reproducibility (Rojas and Madanian, 2026), all data preparation, model training, and evaluation steps were programmatically implemented in Python (version 3.11.16) and chained in a single entry point that runs every step of the study in order, from the construction of the training sets to the final consistency check of the manuscript. The computational environment relied on a standardized core software stack:

- **Cheminformatics and Featurization:** RDKit (version 2025.9.3) (Landrum et al., 2025) executed all molecular parsing, structural standardization, and descriptor generation (2D, 3D, and ECFP4); Open Babel (version 3.1.1) (Babel, 2011) converted the receptor to PDBQT.
- **Classical Machine Learning:** The nested cross-validation framework (Krstajic et al., 2014; Calle et al., 2025) and baseline algorithms leveraged `scikit-learn` (version 1.6.0) (Pedregosa et al., 2011), `xgboost` (version 3.1.2) (Chen and Guestrin, 2016), and `lightgbm` (version 4.6.0) (Ke et al., 2017). Data manipulation, matrix operations, and statistical tests were managed via `pandas` (version 2.3.3) (McKinney et al., 2010), `numpy` (version 1.26.4) (Harris et al., 2020), and `scipy` (version 1.16.3).
- **Deep Learning Infrastructure:** The D-MPNN graph models utilized `chemprop` (version 2.2.4) (Graff et al., 2026; Heid et al., 2023) and `lightning` (version 2.6.5), with underlying tensor operations supported by PyTorch (`torch`, version 2.5.1) (Paszke et al., 2019).
- **Docking:** AutoDock Vina (Python bindings, version 1.2.7) (Trott and Olson, 2010) performed the docking and ligands were prepared with Meeko (version 0.8.0).
- **Hardware Specifications:** All model training, architecture selection, and evaluation protocols ran on an Ubuntu 26.04 LTS workstation with two Intel(R) Xeon(R) E5-2695 v2 processors (24 physical cores, 48 threads, 2.4 GHz) and 247 GB of RAM, using CPU only; no GPU was involved.

All random number generators were seeded (seed 42), and the classical results are bitwise reproducible: the models that enter them are fitted single-threaded and parallelism is applied across independent tasks, so no result depends on how the work was distributed over workers. The graph-model benchmark is the one exception, and it is not a matter of seeding: a network trained on several CPU threads sums floating-point terms in a thread-dependent order, which a fixed seed does not control. The benchmark was executed 3 times with the same code on the same outer folds, and the mean fold R^2 varied by 0.004, a spread an order of magnitude narrower than the confidence interval of the estimate itself ([0.678, 0.772]), so it affects the third decimal of the neural results and none of the comparisons reported here. The Supplementary Material gives the mechanism and the measurement. The wall-clock time of every step was recorded on this machine, without normalizing by thread count, and is reported in Section 3.3.

3. Results

3.1. The Reported Gain and Where It Comes From

Run unmodified, the published code reproduced its own printed results: $R^2 = 0.858$ against the printed 0.858 for the final augmented ensemble, 0.813 against 0.816 and 0.811 against 0.815 for the two feature-selected stages; only the

Table 1
Performance of the original pipeline as each information leak is removed, over 10 seeds. ΔR^2 is the change with respect to the rung above, with its 95% bootstrap confidence interval over the 130 molecules common to rungs R1–R4. R0 builds its own evaluation partition by re-splitting the augmented data, so it shares no test molecules with the rungs below and the difference of R1, which is measured against it, cannot be paired: [a] that one entry is given as the mean over seeds with its standard deviation instead of a bootstrap interval. The last row is a model with no feature selection, fitted on the same clean split; [b] its entry is the difference of R4 with respect to it, not a step of the ladder.

Rung	Leak removed	Features	R^2	ΔR^2
R0	None: the protocol as published	941	0.853 ± 0.007	
R1	Synthetic copies of test molecules reaching the training set	941	0.825 ± 0.005	-0.028 ± 0.007[a]
R2	Early stopping and model choice guided by the test set	945	0.800 ± 0.013	-0.026 [-0.042, -0.011]
R3	Feature importance computed on the test set	385	0.752 ± 0.019	-0.048 [-0.073, -0.013]
R4	The same structure on both sides of the split	330	0.740 ± 0.024	-0.011 [-0.026, $+0.005$]
Clean	Reference: no feature selection at all	1858	0.752 ± 0.008	-0.012 [-0.025, $+0.030$][b]

unselected baseline differed appreciably (0.768 against 0.746). Over 10 seeds the final model gave $R^2 = 0.853 \pm 0.007$, so the published value is not the product of a fortunate seed. What follows therefore concerns the pipeline as published.

Removing its leaks one at a time accounts for most of that value (Table 1). The largest single contribution comes from the step that is hardest to see in the code: the permutation importance that selects the descriptors is computed on the test molecules, which is worth -0.048 in R^2 (95% CI [-0.073, -0.013]). Guiding early stopping with the test set adds -0.026 ([-0.042, -0.011]), and re-partitioning the data after augmentation, which lets a noisy copy of a test molecule train the model, adds -0.028 ± 0.007. This last figure carries no interval because the published protocol scores itself on the partition its own re-splitting produces, so it shares no test molecules with the rungs below it and the difference cannot be paired; it is reported over seeds instead. Each of these three leaks lowers the score in every one of the 10 seeds (Table S1). Removing duplicate structures from both sides of the split costs a further -0.011, the only step whose interval contains zero ([-0.026, $+0.005$]).

Together the four corrections take the model from $R^2 = 0.853$ to 0.740, a drop of -0.113 ± 0.023. The end point cannot be distinguished from a model with no feature selection at all (0.752 ± 0.008; difference -0.012, 95% CI [-0.025, $+0.030$]): once the importance is computed honestly, the selection buys nothing. That level is also the one reported by the original study for its own unselected baseline (0.75) and the one the classical ensembles reach in Section 3.2.

The evaluation partition itself shows the mechanism most directly. Because the published protocol augments the data and then splits it again, the partition it scores as a test set holds 131 molecules, of which 111 come from the original training set and only 20 are molecules the model had not already seen.

The same mechanism is visible in our own classical replication, with no neural network involved. Computing the permutation importance of variant B on the complete data set, as the original study does, instead of on the development partition alone, raises the hold-out R^2 from 0.748 to 0.836 ($\Delta = +0.088$, 95% CI [$+0.047$, $+0.139$]), and that of variant C from 0.732 to 0.826 ($\Delta = +0.095$, [$+0.046$, $+0.153$]). The two procedures do not even select the same features: of the bits retained by either of them, only 32.0% are retained by both (Jaccard index 0.3197), and the leaky selection keeps 446 bits against the 747 of the clean one. Seeing the test molecules does not merely sharpen the choice; it produces a different model. Table S2 gives the five variants of this replication side by side. A leaky selection on a classical learner thus reaches 0.836, close to the 0.82 reported for the feature-selected model of the original study, while the same selection performed correctly reaches 0.748. The gain credited to feature selection is reproducible only when the selection is allowed to see the test data.

3.2. Comparative Performance of Classical ML Across Feature Spaces

We established a baseline for TgDHFR inhibitor prediction by evaluating classical machine learning ensembles across four molecular representations with a 25-fold nested cross-validation framework. Figure 3 shows the distribution of the 25 outer-fold R^2 values of each, in the order used below. The purely structural Morgan fingerprints (ECFP4, 2048 bits) reached $R^2 = 0.769 \pm 0.041$ (MAE = 0.434), the 3D hybrid space $R^2 = 0.774 \pm 0.041$ (MAE = 0.428), and RDKit 2D descriptors combined with fingerprints $R^2 = 0.774 \pm 0.043$ (MAE = 0.428). RDKit 2D descriptors alone

were clearly inferior ($R^2 = 0.728 \pm 0.048$, MAE = 0.468). Figure S1 shows the per-fold values of both metrics with their confidence intervals.

Differences between representations were assessed with Nadeau-Bengio corrected paired t-tests on the shared outer folds. The three fingerprint-containing spaces could not be separated in R^2 (Morgan versus 2D descriptors with fingerprints, $p = 0.5061$; Morgan versus the 3D hybrid, $p = 0.4006$; 2D descriptors with fingerprints versus the 3D hybrid, $p = 0.8243$), and all three pairs are equivalent within the ± 0.05 margin, so the absence of a difference here is a demonstrated equivalence and not an underpowered comparison. In MAE, Morgan trailed the two hybrid spaces by 0.006 and 0.006 pIC_{50} units ($p = 0.2739$ and $p = 0.2563$), a small gap that is no longer significant after Holm adjustment for the six comparisons ($p_{\text{Holm}} = 0.7689$ for both). Table S3 gives the six comparisons in both metrics. In contrast, 2D descriptors alone were significantly worse than every space that includes fingerprints (versus 2D descriptors with fingerprints, $p = 0.0002$; versus the 3D hybrid, $p = 0.0001$; versus Morgan, $p = 0.0020$). Topological fingerprints are therefore the primary driver of predictive capacity, and the ten 3D shape descriptors derived from ETKDGv3 embedding and MMFF94 minimization added no measurable advantage for this benchmark. Because the three fingerprint-containing spaces are equivalent rather than merely indistinguishable, the choice among them for the deployed model is not a choice about accuracy. Morgan fingerprints were adopted for the feature selection, the augmentation study and the virtual screening on that basis: within a set of demonstrated equivalents, they are the only space that needs neither descriptor calculation nor conformer generation.

To rule out chance correlation, the y-randomization tests prescribed by (Rücker et al., 2007) were run in four forms, each with 100 randomizations scored by 5-fold cross-validation (Table S4). Applied to the stacking architecture alone (RF+XGB+SVM: random forest, XGBoost and SVR with a ridge meta-learner, on all 2048 bits), the real model reached $R^2 = 0.779$ (a single 5-fold partition, which explains the small difference from the nested estimate) while the permuted models collapsed to -0.014 ± 0.008, a separation of $Z = 93.9$ standard deviations. The demanding form of the test repeats the whole procedure that produces the deployed screening model, bit selection included, inside every randomization: the separation then falls to $Z = 47.8$ when the response is permuted and to $Z = 27.0$ when the descriptors themselves are replaced by random ones, the smallest of the four and still far outside the randomized distribution. All four reach the smallest p attainable with 100 permutations ($p = 0.0099$ against $\alpha = 0.01$). Neither the architecture nor the selection procedure therefore owes its accuracy to chance correlation.

Architecture selection was only partly stable, and markedly less so outside the Morgan space (Figure 4; Figure S2 gives the full grid of combinations chosen in every fold and representation). Within the Morgan space, Support Vector Regression entered the selected ensemble in 100% of the outer folds, XGBoost in 92% and Random Forest in 84%, followed at a distance by k-nearest neighbors (12%), LightGBM (4%) and Extra Trees (4%); the selected ensembles contained one, two, or three models in 0%, 4%, and 96% of the folds. One combination dominated without being universal: RF+XGB+SVM won 76.0% of the folds (19/25), followed by XGB+SVM+kNN (3/25) and 3 further architectures, none of them chosen in more than 1 of the 25 folds. The descriptor-based spaces were less settled. Their base learners are consistent (Extra Trees entered in 100%, 100%, and 100% of the folds of the 2D, 2D+FP, and 2D+3D+FP spaces, and SVR in 92%, 96%, and 100%), but the exact three-model combination varied much more: the most frequent one was chosen in 52.0%, 32.0%, and 60.0% of the folds, against 76.0% for Morgan. Table S5 reports the composition of the selected ensembles for every representation. Aggregated performance is stable across outer folds, but outside the Morgan space the 859-compound benchmark does not let the inner loop settle on one ensemble, so the reported performance is that of the selection procedure rather than that of a fixed architecture.

We then placed these results against the incremental progression reported in the original study (Table 2). Our classical stacking ensemble trained solely on Morgan features ($R^2 = 0.769$) performed comparably to their unselected 2D/3D/FP baseline ($R^2 = 0.75$); under a Nadeau-Bengio corrected one-sample t-test the difference was not significant ($t = 0.862$, $p = 0.3971$). In contrast, the literature value for the model with permutation-importance feature selection ($R^2 = 0.82$) lies significantly above our nested cross-validated Morgan estimate ($t = -2.339$, $p = 0.0280$), and so does the final data-augmented deep neural network ensemble ($R^2 = 0.85$; $t = -3.712$, $p = 0.0011$). This comparison has a limitation: the original values come from a single hold-out split without a reported dispersion and are treated here as fixed constants, so the test does not capture the sampling variability of that split. Achieving a competitive baseline ($R^2 \approx 0.75$) does not require computationally expensive 3D descriptors or complex neural network architectures; simple 2D fingerprints paired with classical algorithms suffice.

To test whether the interventions credited with the gains of the original study transfer to classical learners, we replicated its protocol (15% hold-out, seed 42; 129 molecules held out before any selection or augmentation, 730 for development) on a stacking ensemble (Figure 5). The unselected baseline reached $R^2 = 0.733$ (MAE = 0.441).

Table 2
Methodological comparison isolating the performance impact of architectural complexity, descriptor dimensionality, and data augmentation in TgDHFR bioactivity prediction.

Model Framework	Descriptors	Data Augmentation	Test R^2 (mean ± std)
Current Study (Classical Ensemble)	ECFP4 (2D)	None	0.769± 0.041
Baseline (Karimova and Senanayake, 2025)	2D/3D/FP	None	0.75[a]
Feature-selected model (Karimova and Senanayake, 2025)	2D/3D/FP (Selected)	None	0.82[a]
Augmented Final Model (Karimova and Senanayake, 2025)	2D/3D/FP (Selected)	Gaussian Noise	0.85[a]

[a] Standard deviation not reported (NR) in the original study.

Permutation-importance selection (747 of 2048 bits retained) yielded $R^2 = 0.748$ (MAE = 0.433), and Gaussian-noise augmentation yielded $R^2 = 0.732$ (MAE = 0.439). Paired bootstrap differences showed no significant effect of either intervention: selection changed R^2 by +0.015 (95% CI [−0.013, +0.043]) and augmentation by −0.001 (95% CI [−0.027, +0.020]) relative to the baseline, and both intervals include zero. The hold-out intervals are wide, spanning roughly 0.2 R^2 units, and contain the original baseline of 0.75; the original values of 0.82 and 0.85 lie above the upper limits of the intervals for selection ($p_{\text{boot}} = 0.0850$) and augmentation ($p_{\text{boot}} = 0.0050$), respectively. The gains reported for the original deep ensemble were therefore not reproduced by feature selection or augmentation applied to a classical learner; they may depend on the neural architecture, or reflect the sampling variability of a single hold-out split. Two properties of the replicated interventions limit how strong this negative result is. First, the permutation importance was computed on the data the model was fitted on, so the selection removes essentially the bits the model never uses and little else, and no change is expected for tree-based learners. Second, Gaussian noise of $\sigma \leq 0.01$ added to binary fingerprint bits barely moves the split thresholds of tree models, so the augmented copies are almost identical to the originals. Neither intervention was therefore a demanding test of its idea.

3.3. Benchmarking Tree-Based Ensembles Against Graph Neural Networks

Graph neural networks learn molecular representations directly from the atom–bond graph, but their advantage is expected to shrink when labeled data are scarce. To test whether representation learning helps on the TgDHFR dataset (859 compounds), a Directed Message Passing Neural Network (D-MPNN, Chemprop) was evaluated on exactly the same 25 outer folds as the classical ensembles, in two variants described in the Methods: default hyperparameters, and a hyperparameter search nested inside each outer fold.

The default D-MPNN reached a mean fold R^2 of 0.725 ± 0.043 and a mean absolute error of 0.474, compared with $R^2 = 0.769 \pm 0.041$ for the Morgan-fingerprint stacking ensemble (Figure 6). Because the folds are shared, the models can be compared with the same Nadeau–Bengio corrected paired t-test used for the classical representations. The network was numerically below the Morgan ensemble ($\Delta R^2 = -0.044$) and the fingerprint-based hybrid ensembles ($\Delta R^2 = -0.049$ and -0.049 against 2D+FP and 2D+3D+FP), and on par with the 2D descriptors alone ($\Delta R^2 = -0.003$, Holm-adjusted $p = 0.866$). After Holm adjustment the three deficits against fingerprint-based ensembles were significant, but only just: the smallest adjusted p was 0.048 for R^2 and 0.019 for MAE, so the evidence sits immediately below the conventional threshold and should be read as a small, consistent shortfall rather than a decisive one.

Tuning did not change this picture. In the nested search, the selected configuration varied across folds (7 of the 8 configurations were chosen at least once, and the default one in only 4% of the folds; Table S6 gives the configuration selected in each fold with its inner error), but the tuned network reached $R^2 = 0.726 \pm 0.034$ and MAE = 0.470, indistinguishable from the default one ($\Delta R^2 = +0.001$, $p = 0.930$; $\Delta\text{MAE} = -0.004$, $p = 0.713$). Against the classical ensembles the tuned network was again numerically lower than Morgan ($\Delta R^2 = -0.043$, Holm-adjusted $p = 0.044$) and the two fingerprint-based hybrids ($\Delta R^2 = -0.047$ and -0.048), and on par with the 2D descriptors ($\Delta R^2 = -0.002$, $p = 0.925$). As for the default network, the deficits against the fingerprint-based ensembles were significant by a narrow margin (smallest adjusted p: 0.041 for R^2 and 0.023 for MAE), and the comparison with the 2D descriptors alone was not.

Table 3
Neural models evaluated on the 25 shared outer folds, ordered by R^2, with the Morgan ensemble and the default D-MPNN as references. ΔR^2 is the difference from the Morgan ensemble, p its Holm-adjusted value within the four classical representations, and p_{equiv} the two one-sided tests against the ± 0.05 margin. Times are the mean wall-clock time of one outer fold and are not normalized by thread count.

Model	R^2	MAE	**min/fold**	ΔR^2	p	p_{equiv}
Morgan ensemble (reference)	0.769 ± 0.041	0.434	33.1	—	—	—
D-MPNN, default	0.725 ± 0.043	0.474	3.0	—	—	—
D-MPNN initialized from CheMeleon	0.761 ± 0.041	0.442	270.0	−0.007	1.000	0.004
Ensemble of 5 D-MPNN	0.741 ± 0.040	0.460	34.6	−0.028	0.162	0.058
MLP on ECFP4	0.709 ± 0.054	0.499	0.5	−0.060	0.097	0.646
D-MPNN with RDKit 2D descriptors	0.701 ± 0.050	0.495	8.1	−0.068	0.012	0.805

Equivalence is a separate question; Table S7 gives every comparison of the two network variants against the four representations, in both metrics, from which the figures below are taken. With the ± 0.05 margin, the tuned network was equivalent to the 2D descriptors in R^2 (90% CI $[-0.037, +0.033]$, $p = 0.013$), but equivalence to the Morgan ensemble could not be shown for R^2 (90% CI $[-0.071, -0.015]$, $p = 0.330$). Equivalence in MAE could not be shown either ($\Delta = +0.036$, 90% CI $[+0.011, +0.062]$, $p = 0.182$), because the upper limit of the interval exceeds the margin. The two tests therefore agree: against the Morgan ensemble the network is neither shown to be equivalent nor comfortably shown to be worse, and the data leave open a deficit in R^2 as large as $\Delta R^2 = -0.071$. Against the 2D descriptors, by contrast, equivalence holds in both metrics ($p = 0.013$ for R^2 and 0.002 for MAE). The tuned search was deliberately modest (Methods), so a larger search or a different architecture could change this.

Both graph-network variants and the classical ensembles fall in the same range as the original study's unselected baseline ($R^2 = 0.75$). The final augmented ensemble of the original study ($R^2 = 0.85$) lies above this range, but, as discussed in Section 3.2, that value comes from a single hold-out split and was not reproduced by selection or augmentation on a classical learner. Under the data volume of this benchmark, the graph architecture therefore did not provide a gain over fixed fingerprints; it trailed the fingerprint-based ensembles by about -0.043 in R^2, a difference whose adjusted p values fall just below 0.05 and which leaves the network on a par with 2D descriptors alone. The defensible reading is that the graph representation, trained this way, buys nothing here, not that it is inferior in principle.

Computational cost does not favor the classical approach in this protocol, but the comparison needs care (Table 4). One default D-MPNN training took about 179 s on the workstation CPU (about 75 minutes for the 25 folds), whereas a classical outer fold with its complete inner search took between 1182 and 2586 s depending on the representation (1987 s, about 13.8 h in total, for Morgan). The default network received no model selection. When it did, in the tuned variant, one outer fold took 2192 s, about 15.2 h of worker time for the whole benchmark. That is more than the 13.8 h of the Morgan protocol, although not more than the most expensive classical representation (2586 s per fold), and the network's search was the smaller of the two. The case for the classical ensembles therefore rests on accuracy that is not lower, on simpler inputs and models that run on a CPU, and on a deployed model that uses only a subset of the fingerprint bits, and not on a shorter benchmark. For the study as a whole, a complete execution from scratch takes on the order of eight days on this workstation, dominated by the three nested cross-validation runs (main, sensitivity and scaffold-grouped, between 46 and 57 hours each) and the y-randomization test (about 19 hours); the repository documents the measured cost of every step.

The gap to the fingerprint ensembles is a property of this training budget rather than of the graph architecture (Table 3). Averaging five D-MPNN over their seeds recovers part of it, to $R^2 = 0.741 \pm 0.040$, and leaves a difference from the Morgan ensemble that no longer reaches significance ($\Delta R^2 = -0.028$, Holm-adjusted $p = 0.162$) although equivalence is still not established in R^2 ($p = 0.058$). Initializing the same network from the CheMeleon pretrained model closes the gap altogether: $R^2 = 0.761 \pm 0.041$ and MAE 0.442, within −0.007 of the Morgan ensemble, and the only model of this study that is statistically equivalent to it in both metrics ($p = 0.004$ for R^2 and 0.007 for MAE). Table S8 gives each of these models against each representation in both metrics. The two models that add information of a different kind did not help: giving the D-MPNN the RDKit descriptors lowered it to 0.701, and a feed-forward network on the same fingerprints the classical ensembles use reached 0.709.

Parity therefore costs something. The pretrained network needed 270.0 minutes per outer fold against the 33.1 minutes of a complete classical fold with its architecture search, a factor of 8.2, and it reaches the accuracy of the

Table 4
Run time and accuracy of every model. Time is the mean wall-clock time of one outer fold on the workstation, including the inner search where one exists, and the 25-fold total is that time multiplied by 25. Times are not normalized by thread count (the classical models used all threads on one fold at a time; the tuned D-MPNN ran two training processes in parallel).

Model	Time per outer fold (s)	25 folds (h)	Configurations searched	R^2
Morgan FP	1987	13.8	41	0.769 ± 0.041
RDKit 2D+FP	2504	17.4	41	0.774 ± 0.043
RDKit 2D+3D+FP	2586	18.0	41	0.774 ± 0.041
RDKit 2D	1182	8.2	41	0.728 ± 0.048
D-MPNN, default	179	1.2	None	0.725 ± 0.043
D-MPNN, tuned	2192	15.2	8	0.726 ± 0.034

Table 5
Cross-validated performance (mean ± SD over 25 outer folds) under random and scaffold-grouped splits, ordered by the size of the drop in mean R^2. Both protocols share their outer partitions across models, so every column is a paired comparison.

		R^2			
Model	Family	Random	Scaffold	Drop	MAE (scaffold)
RDKit 2D ensemble	classical	0.728 ± 0.048	0.492 ± 0.116	0.236	0.673
DNN with selection and augmentation	neural	0.715 ± 0.077	0.510 ± 0.127	0.205	0.611
D-MPNN, default	neural	0.725 ± 0.043	0.521 ± 0.127	0.204	0.647
RDKit 2D+FP ensemble	classical	0.774 ± 0.043	0.571 ± 0.104	0.203	0.613
RDKit 2D+3D+FP ensemble	classical	0.774 ± 0.041	0.574 ± 0.106	0.200	0.612
Ensemble of D-MPNN	neural	0.741 ± 0.040	0.555 ± 0.113	0.186	0.623
DNN baseline	neural	0.673 ± 0.086	0.489 ± 0.169	0.185	0.614
Morgan ensemble	classical	0.769 ± 0.041	0.594 ± 0.097	0.175	0.598
D-MPNN initialized from CheMeleon	neural	0.761 ± 0.041	0.601 ± 0.087	0.161	0.599

fingerprint ensemble without exceeding it. The seed ensemble is the more economical of the two routes, at 34.6 minutes per fold. Read together with the default and tuned variants, these results place the ceiling of representation learning on this data set at the level of a fixed fingerprint, reached only with pretraining on an external corpus.

The architecture of the original study behaves the same way once its protocol is repaired. Evaluated on these folds with the selection and the augmentation confined to each training partition (Section 2.3), the deep ensemble reached $R^2 = 0.673 \pm 0.086$ on all descriptors and 0.715 ± 0.077 with the selection and the augmentation of the original pipeline, a difference of $+0.042$ that the data cannot resolve ($p = 0.414$). Both sit below the Morgan ensemble, by -0.054 for the better of the two, with a confidence interval ($[-0.131, +0.023]$) too wide to settle the comparison. The interventions credited with the reported gain therefore do not reproduce on the architecture they were proposed for either, once the test molecules are kept out of them.

3.4. Robustness to Scaffold-Grouped Splits

Random folds place close analogs of a test compound in the training set, which favors models that memorize local structure. To measure how much of the reported accuracy depends on this, every model of this study was re-evaluated with scaffold-grouped outer folds (Section 2.5), keeping the 25 folds, the hyperparameters and the shared partitions. Table 5 summarizes the outcome.

Holding scaffolds out costs every model between 0.161 and 0.236 units of R^2, with the Morgan ensemble falling from 0.769 to 0.594 (MAE from 0.434 to 0.598) and the default D-MPNN from 0.725 to 0.521 (MAE from 0.474 to 0.647). The fold-to-fold spread also more than doubled (SD of R^2 from 0.041 to 0.097 and from 0.043 to 0.127, respectively), because the difficulty of a fold now depends on which scaffolds it contains. The random-split estimates of the main benchmark therefore overstate the performance expected on new chemotypes.

The size of the drop is not random across models. The two representations that carry the least information beyond the training set lose the most (0.236 for the 2D descriptors), and the two that carry the most lose the least: the Morgan

Table 6
The classical ensemble against the default D-MPNN on 12 external targets. Cliffs is the percentage of compounds the collection flags as activity cliffs. Every ΔR^2 is the classical value minus the neural one, so a positive number favours the classical model. The cross-validated columns are means over 5 outer folds shared by both families within each target, with the Holm-adjusted p of the corrected paired t-test; the last two columns are differences on the partition published with the collection, scored on the whole test part and on its activity cliffs alone.

			Cross-validation (R^2)				Published split	
Target	n	**Cliffs**	Morgan	D-MPNN	ΔR^2	p_{Holm}	All	Cliffs
JAK1 (Ki)	615	7	0.807	0.772	+0.035	0.211	+0.046	+0.101
FXR (EC50)	631	39	0.620	0.509	+0.112	0.276	+0.157	+0.076
AR (Ki)	659	24	0.641	0.570	+0.071	0.314	−0.010	−0.014
GHSR (EC50)	682	48	0.476	0.365	+0.111	0.031	+0.123	+0.193
CLK4 (Ki)	731	9	0.515	0.306	+0.209	0.029	+0.244	+0.601
GR (Ki)	750	31	0.649	0.546	+0.103	0.064	+0.113	+0.017
ABL1 (Ki)	794	32	0.790	0.741	+0.049	0.261	+0.086	+0.022
GSK3 (Ki)	856	18	0.581	0.402	+0.179	0.054	+0.171	+0.268
KOR (EC50)	955	42	0.672	0.596	+0.076	0.067	+0.075	+0.123
PIK3CA (Ki)	960	37	0.674	0.604	+0.069	0.068	+0.031	+0.060
HRH1 (Ki)	973	23	0.740	0.705	+0.035	0.323	+0.063	−0.029
JAK2 (Ki)	976	12	0.830	0.770	+0.060	0.049	+0.075	+0.259

ensemble (0.175) and the pretrained network (0.161), which ends as the highest-scoring model of the scaffold protocol (0.601 ± 0.087) although it cannot be separated from the Morgan ensemble there either ($\Delta R^2 = +0.007$, Holm-adjusted $p = 0.925$; equivalent in MAE, $p = 0.006$). Pretraining on an external corpus thus buys robustness to a change of chemotype rather than accuracy within one, which is the one advantage of representation learning that this benchmark does show.

The comparison between families kept its direction but not its resolution. Under scaffold splits the D-MPNN was lower than the Morgan ensemble by $\Delta R^2 = -0.073$ (corrected $p = 0.368$, Holm-adjusted; $\Delta\text{MAE} = +0.049$, $p = 0.464$). The 90% confidence interval of the R^2 difference, $[-0.144, -0.002]$, excludes zero only barely, and its lower limit extends far beyond the ± 0.05 equivalence margin; the equivalence test was accordingly not significant ($p = 0.707$). The interval carries no multiplicity adjustment while the p values do, which is why the two do not point the same way; Table S9 gives both the unadjusted and the adjusted values for every comparison under this protocol. With the present data we can thus neither claim a difference nor equivalence between the two families on new scaffolds; the sample (859 compounds) is too small to separate them given the larger variance of this protocol.

3.5. External Replication Across Twelve Bioactivity Targets

Every result so far concerns one target, so the comparison between model families was repeated unchanged on 12 external targets (Section 2.7). What follows is a replication and not a discovery: the authors of that collection already reported that classical models on fixed descriptors match or outperform neural ones on these data (van Tilborg et al., 2022). Its purpose here is the scope of the present claims. The audit of Section 3.1 quantified the leaks of one published pipeline on one target, and the benchmark that followed compared families on that same target; the cohort establishes whether that comparison is a peculiarity of TgDHFR. Table 6 reports every target.

Under cross-validation the classical ensemble on Morgan fingerprints scored higher than the default D-MPNN on all 12 targets (0.666 against 0.574 in mean R^2 over targets), by between +0.035 and +0.209 units. Taking the targets as the replicates, the mean advantage is +0.092 R^2 (95 % CI [+0.058, +0.127], one-sample t $p = 0.0001$, exact Wilcoxon $p = 0.0005$), and MAE agrees (+0.056 pIC_{50} units, $p =< 0.0001$). Within a single target the evidence is far weaker, and the distinction matters: only 3 of the 12 targets reach Holm-adjusted significance on their own 5 folds, while none reaches equivalence either (smallest $p = 0.287$). A target of this size cannot separate the two families; what carries the result is that the direction never changes across 12 independent data sets. The ordering between representations also reproduced: the Morgan fingerprints beat the RDKit 2D descriptors on 10 of the 12 targets, as they did on TgDHFR.

The published partition gives the same answer with the authors' own split rather than ours. The classical ensemble is ahead on 11 of 12 targets (0.656 against 0.559 in mean R^2; mean advantage +0.098, 95 % CI [+0.054, +0.142], t $p = 0.0005$, Wilcoxon $p = 0.0010$), the single exception being the androgen receptor (-0.010). The activity cliffs of

Table 7
Nested cross-validation performance without (primary analysis, $n = 859$) and with ($n = 861$) the two extreme-potency records. p-values compare the two runs with a Welch test using the Nadeau-Bengio variance correction (Nadeau and Bengio, 2003); the runs use different fold partitions, so folds are not paired.

	R^2				MAE			
Representation	Without	With	Δ	p	Without	With	Δ	p
RDKit 2D+3D FP	0.774	0.754	-0.020	0.52	0.428	0.440	+0.012	0.62
RDKit 2D FP	0.774	0.753	-0.020	0.53	0.428	0.439	+0.011	0.64
Morgan FP	0.769	0.750	-0.019	0.56	0.434	0.449	+0.015	0.53
RDKit 2D	0.728	0.709	-0.019	0.63	0.468	0.482	+0.014	0.61

that partition are where fixed fingerprints are expected to fail, since a cliff pair is similar in structure and far apart in potency, and this is the subset the collection was built to expose (van Tilborg et al., 2022). Both families do degrade on it, and heavily: the classical ensemble falls from 0.710 on the remaining compounds to 0.453 on the cliffs, the network from 0.613 to 0.313. The classical advantage, however, does not shrink there. It is +0.140 on the cliffs (95 % CI [+0.028, +0.251], Wilcoxon $p = 0.0049$, classical ahead on 10 of 12) against +0.097 on the rest, so the weakness that the graph architecture is expected to remedy is not remedied here. These subsets hold 13 to 91 compounds, which is why the interval is wide and why this is stated as a result about the cohort and not about any target in it.

On the 2 targets where the default network falls furthest behind, the nested hyperparameter search of Section 2.6 reduced the classical advantage from +0.209 to +0.200 on CLK4 and from +0.111 to +0.088 on GHSR, a gain of 0.009 and 0.023 units of R^2. After tuning, neither difference remains Holm-significant (0 of 2), and this is the point at which the two tests have to be read together: neither target shows equivalence either (0 of 2), so the lost significance reflects what 5 folds can resolve rather than a gap that closed. Tuning the network moved the comparison by a fraction of the distance that separates the families.

Two limits of this cohort should be read with its result. It restricts itself to targets of at most 1000 compounds, so it replicates the comparison in the regime of a few hundred to a thousand labeled molecules and says nothing about larger data sets. And the neural side is a graph network trained from scratch: the pretrained model that reached equivalence with the Morgan ensemble on TgDHFR (Section 3.3) was not run on these targets, because its cost per fold (Section 3.3) makes 12 targets unaffordable. What the cohort therefore shows is that a default message-passing network does not match a classical ensemble in this regime, on twelve targets instead of one; the one neural model that did match it on TgDHFR needed external pretraining, and whether that holds across targets is open.

3.6. Sensitivity to Extreme Potency Values

The two records excluded by the Tukey rule (Section 2.1) were retained in a second, complete execution of the nested cross-validation benchmark ($n = 861$ versus $n = 859$ in the primary analysis; identical algorithms, search space and 5×5 protocol). If these records were informative members of the chemical series, retaining them should not degrade generalization; if they are outliers, retaining them should lower accuracy. Table 7 reports the outcome.

Retaining the two records lowered R^2 in all four representations (ΔR^2 between -0.020 and -0.019) and raised the MAE (ΔMAE between +0.011 and +0.015 pIC_{50} units), a consistent direction that is nevertheless indistinguishable from fold-to-fold variability (p between 0.52 and 0.64). For the Morgan representation, R^2 moved from 0.769 to 0.750 ($p = 0.56$). The ordering of the three best representations changed between runs, but their differences were already within noise in the primary analysis, so the central conclusion (no representation is reliably superior) holds in both.

To test whether the records are predictable at all, a Morgan fingerprint Random Forest trained on the primary set was asked to predict them. The record at $pIC_{50} = 11.68$ was predicted as 6.59 (absolute error 5.09) and the record at 1.56 as 4.98 (error 3.42), that is, 8.2 and 5.5 times the out-of-fold RMSE of that model (0.62), and larger than every out-of-fold error among the 859 retained compounds.

The exclusion rule was fixed before any model was fitted (Section 2.1), so what this section tests is not whether the records should have been removed but whether their removal changes any conclusion, and it does not: every comparison reported in this study holds on the sensitivity benchmark. The two records do behave as outliers with respect to the model, in that they cannot be anticipated from the structure–activity relationship learned from the rest of the series, and keeping them modestly worsens, without significantly altering, the reported metrics. That observation corroborates the

pre-specified decision; it is not what motivates it. We note that the high-potency record may be a genuine measurement of a very potent antifolate rather than an error; in either case it lies outside the domain that the present data can support.

3.7. Hypothesis Generation: Screening and Docking

The deployed model, the feature-selected Morgan-fingerprint stacking ensemble of the augmentation experiment (Section 3.2), was applied to the FDA-approved library after the funnel described in the Methods: 3378 compounds were reduced to 3056 by the size and elemental filters, and all of these were scored. Their mean Tanimoto similarity to the five most similar training compounds had a median of 0.17 (5th–95th percentile 0.11–0.26), against 0.70 for the training compounds measured against each other, and only 14 of them reached the applicability-domain threshold of 0.638. The predicted potencies of this library are therefore mostly extrapolations, and each candidate's similarity to the training set is reported with its prediction; of the 17 candidates advanced to docking, 6 were inside the domain, and every one of those is a compound of the training set, so 0 candidates are at once supported by the applicability domain and absent from the data the model was fitted on. A ranking by predicted potency therefore mixes two kinds of entry that have to be read differently: training compounds, whose predictions are fitted values, and extrapolations beyond the domain. The individual predictions are also imprecise: calibrated on the 129 held-out compounds, the 90 % conformal interval of this ensemble is ± 0.99 pIC_{50} units, so a compound predicted at 8 cannot be distinguished from one an order of magnitude less potent, and the admissible threshold of the domain changes the count of supported predictions by no more than a factor of two in either direction (Table S10). Both bounds point the same way: the ranking orders hypotheses, not potencies. As a consistency check, pyrimethamine was predicted at pIC_{50} 6.57 (experimental 6.56) and trimethoprim at 5.67 (experimental 5.57); both belong to the training partition, so this verifies that the final model fits its training data and says nothing about generalization.

Table S11 and Figures S3–S5 give the ranking with its efficiency metrics. The antifolates methotrexate, trimetrexate and pralatrexate lead by absolute potency, but potency scales with molecular size and their efficiency is modest (ligand efficiency between 0.27 and 0.40, against the value of 0.30 commonly taken as the lower bound of a good lead (Hopkins et al., 2004, 2014)); methotrexate is also in the training set, so its rank partly reflects memorization. Size-corrected metrics reorder the list: triamterene, which is absent from the training data, combines a predicted pIC_{50} of 7.01 with the highest ligand efficiency (0.51) and binding efficiency index (27.7) of the table, and is therefore the clearest repurposing hypothesis of the ML stage. It is also the clearest illustration of what such a hypothesis is worth here: its similarity to the training set is 0.60, below the threshold of 0.638, so the prediction is an extrapolation, and the conformal interval places its potency anywhere between 6.02 and 8.00.

Because neither ligand-based prediction nor docking is reliable alone, the 17 candidates were scored by both and classified by agreement (Figure 7), a compound being a consensus hit when the model predicts it active ($pIC_{50} > 6.5$) and it docks favorably ($\Delta G < -8.0$ kcal/mol). This yielded 4 entries (4 unique compounds): pralatrexate ($pIC_{50} = 7.0034$, $\Delta G = -8.68$ kcal/mol, the best docking score of the set), methotrexate (7.4448, -8.66), trimetrexate glucuronate (7.9272, -8.76) and triamterene (7.0081, -8.07). Agreement between the two methods is weak: Spearman's rank correlation between predicted pIC_{50} and Vina score was $\rho = -0.313$ ($p = 0.2218$), with the expected sign but no statistical significance, and the estimate is less informative than its $N = 17$ suggests, because the four trimethoprim entries share one structure and one docking score. We therefore read the correlation only as evidence that docking does not reproduce the ML ranking.

The discordant cases bound both methods. Pyrimethamine, an established TgDHFR inhibitor, docked at only $\Delta G = -7.62$ kcal/mol and trimethoprim similarly ($\Delta G = -7.56$ kcal/mol); small ligands obtain modest Vina scores because the score grows with the number of contacts, which points to a limited sensitivity of the scoring function for small inhibitors rather than to an ML artifact. Bisacodyl is the opposite case, favored by docking ($\Delta G = -8.82$ kcal/mol) while the model predicted $pIC_{50} = 4.9528$; it carries none of the diaminopyrimidine-like features of the antifolate ligands in the training set, so a docking artifact of a flexible, hydrophobic ligand is the more plausible explanation. Without experimental data we cannot arbitrate between the two methods.

This whole stage is a computational prioritization. The receptor is rigid, no water molecules or protonation states are modelled, and Vina scores are empirical estimates. Most of the library lies outside the applicability domain of the model, and selectivity against human DHFR was not assessed. The consensus hits are therefore hypotheses for experimental testing and not confirmed inhibitors.

4. Discussion

4.1. The Role of Explicit Inductive Bias in Small-Scale Molecular Datasets

Graph neural networks can learn molecular features directly from graph topology, which removes the need for hand-designed descriptors, but this flexibility is usually paid for with training data. In our benchmark, with only 859 compounds, the D-MPNN reached $R^2 = 0.725$ with default hyperparameters and 0.726 after a nested hyperparameter search, numerically below the Morgan-fingerprint ensemble ($\Delta R^2 = -0.044$ and -0.043, respectively) by margins that cleared multiple-comparison correction only narrowly, and statistically indistinguishable from the 2D descriptors alone (Section 3.3). Tuning itself changed nothing detectable ($\Delta R^2 = +0.001$), and the configuration chosen by the search varied from fold to fold. In this dataset, therefore, learning the representation brought no detectable gain over using a fixed one.

A plausible reading is that explicit chemical priors matter when labels are scarce. A circular fingerprint hands the learner a fixed, chemically motivated description of substructures, whereas a message-passing network must learn an equivalent description from a few hundred molecules and a noisy target. We stress that this is an interpretation, not a result of this study: no experiment isolates the inductive bias. The network search was modest (8 configurations, one inner split), but the gap it leaves is not an artifact of that budget. Averaging five networks over their seeds removes most of it, and initializing the message passing from a model pretrained on an external corpus removes it entirely, to the point of statistical equivalence with the Morgan ensemble in both metrics (Section 3.3). What the benchmark measures is therefore not a ceiling of the graph architecture but the price of reaching the same accuracy: parity required external data and 8.2 times the computation of the classical protocol, and no model we ran exceeded the fingerprint ensemble.

The augmentation experiments argue against one common remedy. The original study attributed part of its gains to Gaussian-noise augmentation and permutation-importance feature selection applied to a deep ensemble. Applied to a classical stacking ensemble under the same hold-out protocol, neither intervention improved on the unaugmented baseline (Figure 5): selection changed R^2 by $+0.015$ and augmentation by -0.001, with confidence intervals that include zero (Section 3.2). This shows that the gains of the original study did not transfer to a classical learner under these implementations, which are weak tests for tree-based models (the selection only removes unused bits and the noise is negligible for binary inputs; Section 3.2). The audit of Section 3.1 explains where those gains come from: removing the leaks of the published code one at a time lowers its R^2 to the level of a model with no selection at all, and performing the same selection leakily on a classical learner reproduces them. The interventions themselves are therefore not what the reported improvement measures.

The practical conclusion is limited to this regime. For a dataset of this size, a classical ensemble on Morgan fingerprints is a sound default: it performed at least as well as every neural model we tested, and the only one that matched it needed pretraining on an external corpus and far more computation, while the ensemble itself keeps simpler inputs and fewer moving parts. Whether the balance changes with more data is an open question that these results cannot address; larger datasets are generally expected to favor learned representations, but we did not measure a learning curve, and the point at which a graph network would overtake fixed fingerprints is likely to depend on the target and on how well the network is tuned.

That conclusion no longer rests on one target. Repeated unchanged on 12 external targets of between 615 and 976 compounds, the comparison came out the same way every time: the classical ensemble was ahead on all 12 of them under cross-validation, and on 11 of them on the partitions published with the collection (Section 3.5). This replicates a published result rather than establishing a new one (van Tilborg et al., 2022), and the distinction is worth making explicitly. What the cohort buys is scope: the comparison between families becomes a statement about a regime, supported by 12 data sets instead of one. What this study contributes is the measurement of where a reported gain came from, and there the protocol outweighed the architecture. Removing the leaks of the published code one at a time produced a drop of -0.113 in R^2, more than twice the magnitude of the -0.044 that separates the best classical representation from the default graph network on the same data. Those two numbers come from different designs, a hold-out ladder and 25 shared folds, so they are magnitudes placed side by side and not a tested difference; but their ordering is what an audit can add to a literature that argues mostly about architectures.

4.2. Dimensionality, Conformational Overhead, and Model Efficiency

Richer molecular representations are only worth their cost if they add predictive information. Three-dimensional descriptors are the most expensive to obtain, since they require conformer embedding (ETKDGv3) and force-field minimization (MMFF) for every molecule. Our comparison separates what each block of features contributes

(Section 3.2). The 2D physicochemical descriptors alone were clearly the weakest representation ($R^2 = 0.728$, against 0.769 for Morgan fingerprints; $\Delta R^2 = 0.041$, Holm-adjusted $p = 0.0081$). Adding fingerprints to them recovered the difference ($R^2 = 0.774$), and adding the ten 3D descriptors on top changed nothing detectable ($R^2 = 0.774$; $\Delta R^2 = 0.001$, $p = 0.8243$). Morgan fingerprints alone were within 0.005 of the 2D+3D+FP set in R^2 (Holm-adjusted $p = 1.0000$). The hybrid sets had a slightly lower MAE than Morgan alone ($\Delta = 0.006$), but this was not significant after correction ($p = 0.7689$). In this dataset the fingerprint block carries the predictive signal, and neither the descriptors nor the 3D block added a detectable amount to it. Two limits bound that conclusion, and they are distinct. The first is the width of the 3D block: ten shape descriptors could miss information that a richer 3D representation would capture. The second is conformational sampling, which is the stronger caveat: every 3D descriptor here was computed on one ETKDGv3 conformer per molecule, so the geometry entering the model is a single point of a conformational ensemble, chosen by a fixed seed. A representation built on multiple conformers, or on the bound pose, could carry information that this one cannot, and the result reported here does not speak against that. What it does establish is that the shape summary of a single low-energy conformer, which is the form in which 3D descriptors usually enter tabular QSAR, adds nothing detectable on this target.

The cost side is less clear-cut than usually assumed. For the 859 compounds, computing the features took 0.4 s for Morgan fingerprints and 6.9 s for the full 2D+3D+FP set on matrices of 2048 and 2275 features, respectively (wall-clock time with parallel workers on the workstation). The 3D set is the more expensive, but the absolute difference is a few seconds. The cost of a complete outer fold, with its inner architecture search, was instead dominated by model fitting: between 1182 and 2586 s on average across the four representations (1987 s for Morgan), without a clear relation to whether 3D descriptors were present (Figure 8). At this scale, then, conformer generation was not the bottleneck. We did not measure how the cost of 3D features grows for libraries of millions of compounds, where it could matter, and the deployed screening model does not use them: it takes only the 747 selected Morgan bits, which are computed from the 2D structure.

The parsimonious choice for this target is therefore the 2D fingerprint ensemble. This is a statement about information content and about the inputs the screening step needs, not a measured speed advantage; as shown in Section 3.3, the end-to-end benchmark of the classical protocol was not faster than the graph network.

4.3. Methodological Scope, Limitations, and Translational Potential

The reliability of any quantitative structure–activity relationship (QSAR) model is bounded by the chemical diversity of its training data. With 859 compounds, the applicability domain of the ensemble is restricted to the scaffolds and physicochemical ranges of the curated TgDHFR set, and the FDA drugs are far from it: their median similarity to the five nearest training compounds is 0.17, against 0.70 for the training compounds among themselves, so most predicted potencies in the screening are extrapolations that the applicability domain cannot vouch for. The cross-validation estimate also needs a caveat: the main folds were random, and scaffold-grouped splits (Section 3.4) lowered R^2 for every model, by 0.175 for the Morgan ensemble (from 0.769 to 0.594) and 0.204 for the D-MPNN (from 0.725 to 0.521). The reported R^2 therefore describes interpolation among related compounds, and the expected accuracy on the structurally distant drugs of the FDA library is closer to the scaffold-split values. We did not evaluate temporal splits. The predicted potencies of those drugs have no experimental counterpart in this study.

Activity cliffs are a specific weakness of 2D circular fingerprints in this setting: very similar molecules can differ strongly in activity, and a Morgan bit vector may map them to nearly the same representation (van Tilborg et al., 2022). We did not measure how many cliffs the TgDHFR set contains or how the model behaves on them, and that gap remains for this target. On the external cohort, where the collection distributes a cliff flag for every compound of its published test partitions, the measurement was possible and it did not run as expected (Section 3.5): both families lost a large part of their accuracy on the flagged compounds, the classical ensemble falling from 0.710 to 0.453 in mean R^2 and the network from 0.613 to 0.313, but the classical advantage was larger on the cliffs (+0.140) than on the remaining compounds (+0.097). Learning the representation from the graph did not repair on these targets the weakness that fixed fingerprints are expected to have, which is an argument against reading the cliff problem as a representation problem alone; both model families are limited by the same thing, that two molecules the data call nearly identical carry different labels. The docking step does not remove the problem either; it adds an independent estimate, but a rigid-receptor Vina score is itself unreliable for small differences between close analogs, as the discordance for pyrimethamine in Section 3.7 illustrates.

The inner architecture search is a further source of instability. Evaluating 41 stacking combinations per outer fold carries a risk of selection bias. The nested design keeps this search away from the outer test folds, so the estimate is not

inflated by it, but the chosen architecture varied across folds, and the Morgan space was the most settled of the four: its most frequent combination, RF+XGB+SVM, was selected in 76.0% of the 25 folds, against 32.0% for the least settled space (Figure S2). With a data set of this size the inner loop does not converge on a single architecture, and the reported performance should be read as that of the selection procedure and not of one fixed ensemble.

The applicability domain shows how little of this library the model can speak to: only 14 of the 3056 scored compounds reach the similarity threshold, a count that no admissible choice of that threshold changes by more than a factor of two (Table S10), so for the rest a predicted potency is an extrapolation whatever its value. The candidates that reached docking make the point sharper: 6 of them lie inside the domain and all of them are training compounds, so none is at once domain-supported and new, and the one prediction per compound carries a conformal interval of ± 0.99 pIC_{50} units in any case. That is the main reason to read this stage as hypothesis generation. It also bears on the ranking itself: the antifolates that lead it inhibit the human enzyme as well, and selectivity against human DHFR was not assessed here, so a high predicted potency is not by itself a reason to prefer a compound.

The most important translational limitation is selectivity. Pralatrexate, methotrexate and trimetrexate are anticancer antifolates that inhibit human dihydrofolate reductase, and are cytotoxic to host cells. Our pipeline predicts potency against the parasite enzyme and ranks docking energies against it, but it does not assess selectivity over the human enzyme, so a high rank should not be mistaken for a therapeutic candidate. The consensus hits are best read as computational hypotheses: compounds whose predicted activity is supported by two independent methods and that merit selectivity docking against human DHFR and experimental testing. What does transfer to other targets, and what does not, can now be stated with some precision. The benchmark at the centre of this study, the classical ensembles against a graph network on shared folds, was run on 12 further targets and gave the same answer on each (Section 3.5), so that part of the design is not specific to TgDHFR. The rest of the pipeline was not: the leakage audit addresses one published implementation, and the screening, docking and applicability-domain steps were run for this target alone. Three boundaries remain even for the part that was replicated. The cohort stops at 1000 compounds per target, so it speaks to the small-sample regime and not beyond it. Its neural side is a network trained from scratch, since the pretrained model that matched the ensemble here was too expensive to run twelve times, which leaves the one architecture that achieved parity untested across targets. And its classical side selects an architecture while the network does not, an asymmetry that tuning the network on the two worst targets reduced without reversing (Section 2.7).

4.4. Conclusions and Future Directions

This study compared classical machine learning ensembles with a graph neural network on a small TgDHFR data set ($N = 859$), under a leakage-free nested cross-validation protocol, repeated that comparison on 12 external targets, and applied the best classical model to a library of FDA-approved drugs with an orthogonal docking check. Three conclusions follow.

First, on this data set a classical stacking ensemble on 2D Morgan fingerprints performed at least as well as the alternatives we tested. It reached $R^2 = 0.769 \pm 0.041$, against 0.725 ± 0.043 for a default D-MPNN and 0.726 ± 0.034 for one tuned in a nested search; the difference ($\Delta R^2 = -0.043$ for the tuned network) was small but survived multiple-comparison correction, and equivalence with the Morgan ensemble could not be established in either metric, so the network as usually trained is behind the fingerprint-based ensembles rather than interchangeable with them. The gap is one of training budget and not of architecture: averaging five networks narrows it, and a D-MPNN initialized from a pretrained model reaches 0.761 and is the only model equivalent to the Morgan ensemble in both metrics, at 8.2 times the computational cost and without exceeding it. Adding 3D descriptors to the fingerprint-based sets changed nothing detectable. Feature selection and Gaussian-noise augmentation, which the original study credited with large gains, did not improve a classical learner under the same hold-out protocol. Those gains are accounted for by information leaks: removing them one at a time from the published code takes its R^2 from 0.853 to 0.740, and the same selection applied leakily to a classical learner reproduces them (0.836 against 0.748). The comparison between the two families is not specific to this target. Repeated on 12 external bioactivity sets of 615 to 976 compounds, the classical ensemble was ahead of the default network on every one of them (mean advantage +0.092 R^2, 95 % CI [+0.058, +0.127]) and on 11 of 12 on the partitions their authors published, which replicates a result those authors had already reported (van Tilborg et al., 2022). Two limits of that replication should travel with it: it covers targets of at most 1000 compounds, and its neural side is a network trained from scratch, so the pretrained architecture that achieved parity here remains untested across targets. These findings do not show that graph networks cannot match fixed fingerprints. The classical protocol was also not cheaper to run: the benchmark took longer than the network's, and its advantage lies in accuracy that is not lower, simpler inputs, and a deployed model that needs only a subset of fingerprint bits.

Second, nested cross-validation and a careful curation of the data (removal of duplicates and of two extreme potency values, with a sensitivity analysis of the latter) were necessary to obtain estimates that can be compared across models. Our random-split estimates are also optimistic: with scaffold-grouped splits every model lost between 0.161 and 0.236 units of R^2 (to 0.594 for the Morgan ensemble and 0.521 for the D-MPNN), and the data could not resolve the differences between them. The loss was smallest for the pretrained network, so what representation learning offers on this data set is robustness to a change of chemotype rather than accuracy within one.

Third, combining ML prediction with docking produced a short, reproducible list of hypotheses and not validated leads. Only 14 of the 3056 scored compounds fell inside the model's applicability domain, the agreement between predicted potency and docking energy was weak ($\rho = -0.313$, $p = 0.2218$), and the compounds leading the ranking by potency are antifolates that also inhibit the human enzyme, whose selectivity was not assessed.

Future work should therefore (i) dock the consensus hits against human DHFR and test them in enzymatic assays against TgDHFR, (ii) evaluate temporal splits, (iii) run the pretrained graph models across the external targets, where cost confined them to one, and (iv) audit further published pipelines, since the leakage measurement reported here covers a single implementation while the benchmark around it now covers 12 targets.

Availability of data and materials

All source code and every data set used in this study are publicly available at https://github.com/aavzpy2023/MLvsGNN

Competing interests

The authors declare that they have no competing interests.

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Authors' contributions

A.V.-Z.: conceptualization, methodology, formal analysis, software, validation, investigation, writing – original draft, visualization. J.C.-G.: methodology, validation, writing – review & editing, supervision. S.M.-S.: validation, writing – review & editing, supervision. R.A.-C.: validation, supervision, writing – review & editing, visualization. All authors read and approved the final manuscript.

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Declaration of generative AI use

During the preparation of this work, the authors utilized generative artificial intelligence technologies (large language models) solely to assist with language polishing, structural formatting, and improving the overall readability of the manuscript. After using these tools, the authors thoroughly reviewed, edited, and validated all generated text. The authors take full and sole responsibility for the final content, scientific integrity, and accuracy of this publication. No AI technologies were used to generate data, perform statistical analyses, or draw scientific conclusions.

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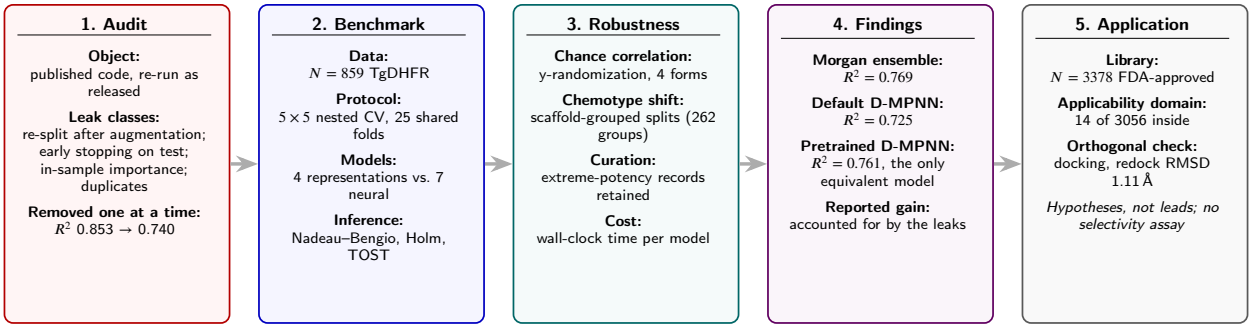


Figure 1: Structure of the study. The published pipeline is first re-executed and taken apart one leak at a time, which measures what each class of leak contributes to its reported R^2 (1). The same data are then used for a leakage-free benchmark in which every model is scored on identical outer folds and every comparison is corrected for the overlap of training sets and tested for equivalence (2), and the conclusions are checked against chance correlation, a harder splitting scheme, the curation decision and computational cost (3). The findings (4) are that a fingerprint ensemble is not outperformed by a graph network at this data volume, that only a pretrained network reaches equivalence with it, and that the gain reported by the original study is accounted for by the leaks removed in (1). The final model is applied to approved drugs as hypothesis generation, with each candidate placed relative to the applicability domain (5).

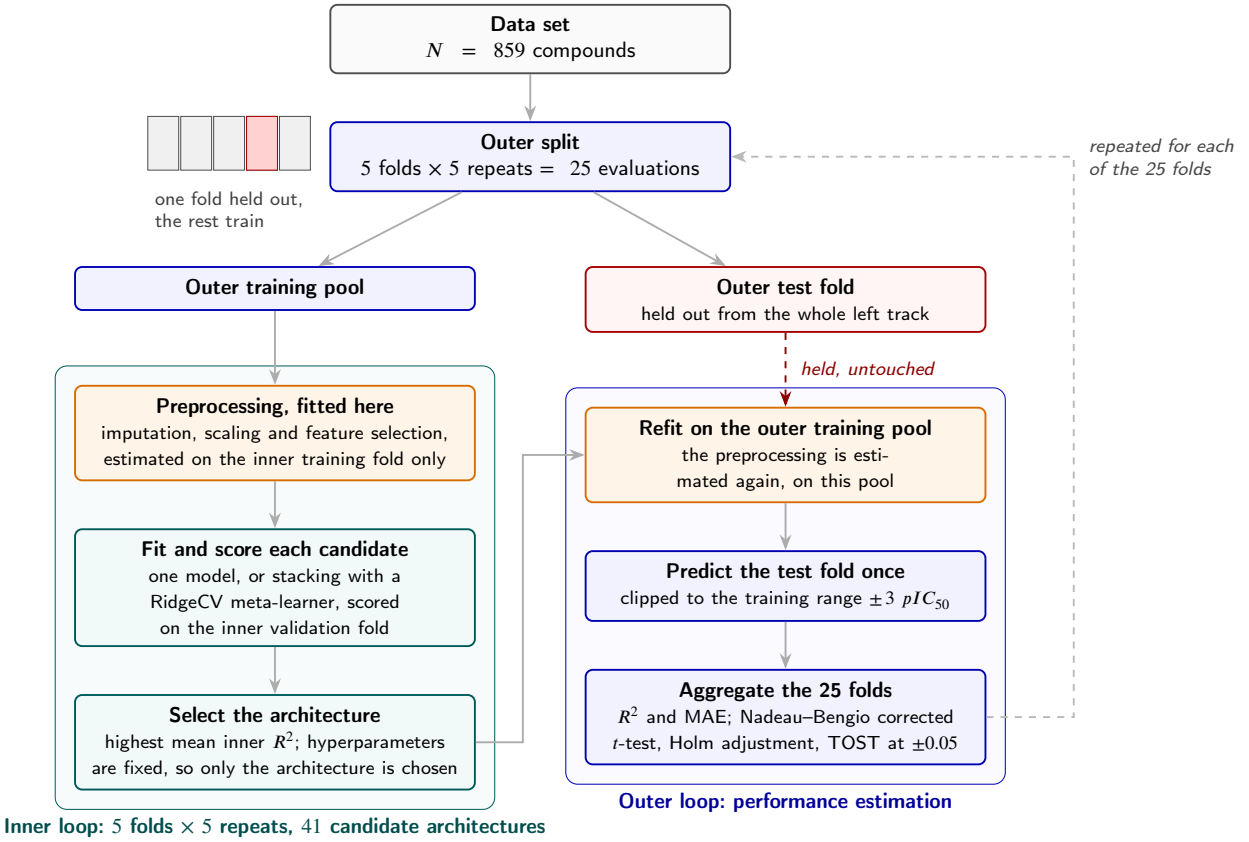


Figure 2: Nested cross-validation: one outer fold of the protocol. The strip at the top left is what one fold is: the data set cut into 5 parts, one held out and the rest training. The diagram follows a single such fold, and the dashed arrow on the right closes the loop: everything in it happens 25 times, and the reported accuracy is the aggregate of those 25 estimates, not one split. Within a fold, the split sends the training pool down the left track and the test fold down the right one. The inner loop selects an architecture among the 41 candidates without ever seeing the test fold, which is held untouched; only the chosen architecture crosses to the right track, where it is refit and scored once. The two orange boxes are the reason the estimate is leakage-free: imputation, scaling and supervised feature selection are not computed once on the whole data set but estimated again inside each partition they are used in, first on the inner training fold during selection and then on the outer training pool for the final fit, and applied to held-out data without re-estimation. Because the 25 outer partitions are shared by every representation and every model, all comparisons in this study are paired on the same molecules.

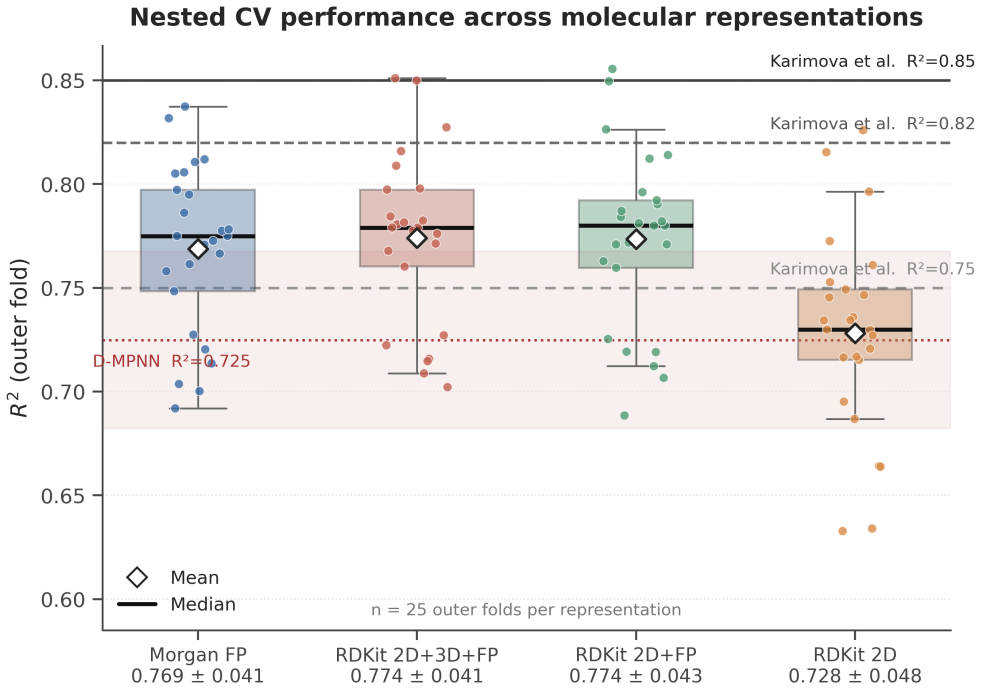


Figure 3: Nested cross-validation R^2 across four molecular representations (each point is one of the 25 outer folds). Horizontal lines mark the three values reported in the original study (Karimova and Senanayake, 2025); the dotted line and band show the mean ± SD of the D-MPNN benchmarked in Section 3.3. The three representations that contain fingerprints—Morgan, RDKit 2D+FP and RDKit 2D+3D+FP—are equivalent in R^2 within the ±0.05 margin, while RDKit 2D descriptors alone are significantly worse.

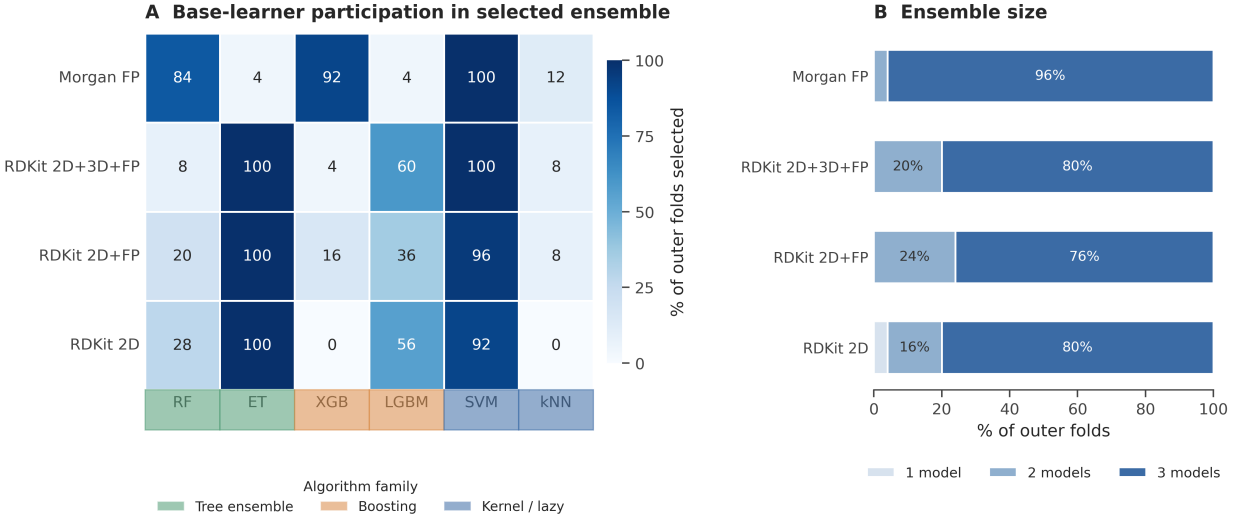


Figure 4: Composition of the stacking ensembles selected by the inner loop in the 25 outer folds. (A) Percentage of folds in which each base learner entered the selected ensemble, per representation. (B) Distribution of ensemble size (one, two, or three base models). No single architecture dominates in the Morgan space.

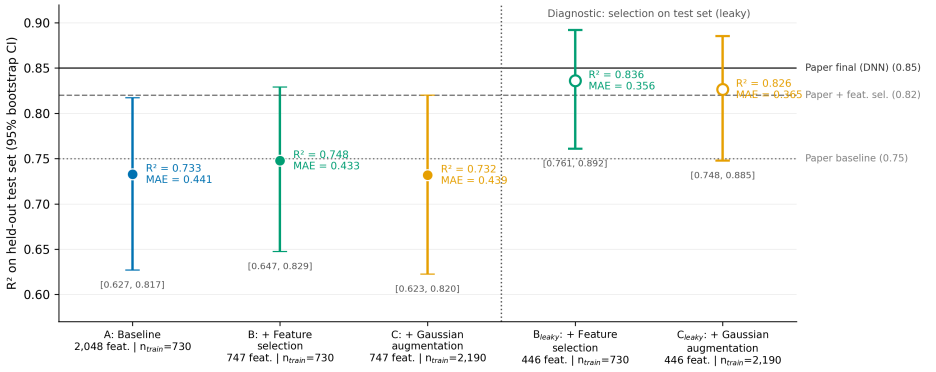


Figure 5: Replication of the original hold-out protocol on a classical stacking ensemble (129 held-out molecules). Points are R^2 on the test set with 95% bootstrap confidence intervals for the baseline (A), permutation-importance feature selection (B), and feature selection plus Gaussian-noise augmentation (C); horizontal lines mark the values reported in the original study (Karimova and Senanayake, 2025).

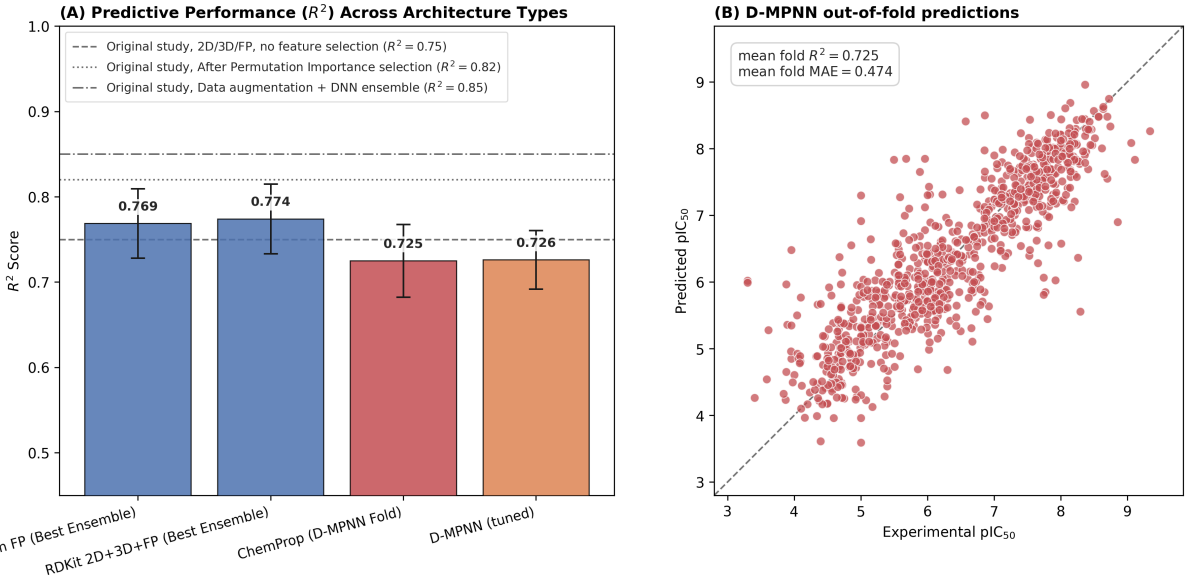


Figure 6: (A) Mean R^2 over the 25 shared outer folds for the best classical ensembles and the D-MPNN with default and tuned hyperparameters; error bars are the standard deviation across folds, and horizontal lines mark the values reported in the original study. (B) Default D-MPNN predicted versus experimental pIC$_{50}$ for every compound, averaged over the five repeats of the cross-validation (each prediction comes from a model that did not see the compound).

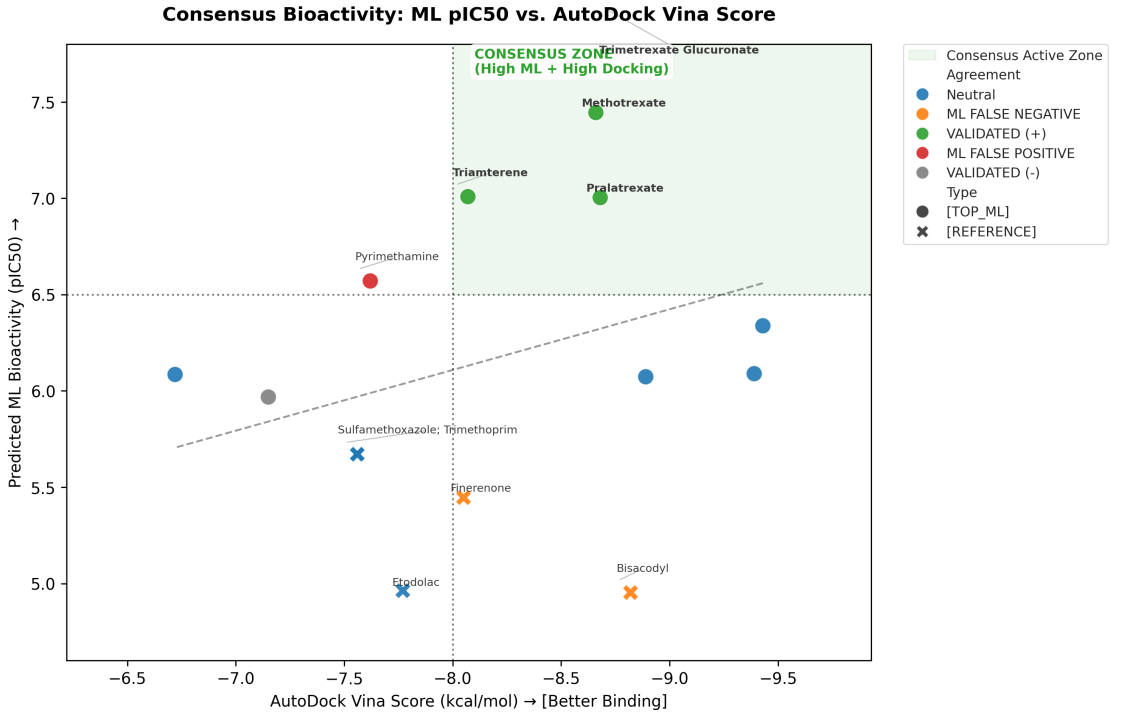


Figure 7: Predicted pIC_{50} versus AutoDock Vina score for the 17 docked candidates, coloured by agreement class. The shaded region is the consensus zone ($pIC_{50} > 6.5$ and $\Delta G < -8.0$ kcal/mol).

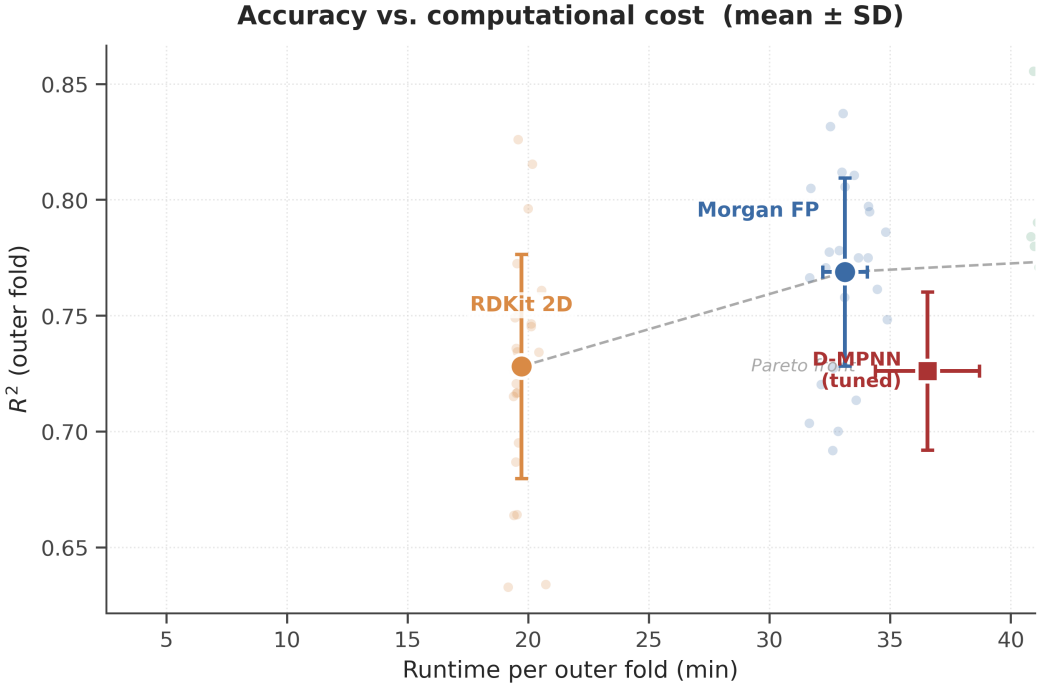


Figure 8: Accuracy versus run time per outer fold (mean ± SD over the 25 folds; faint dots are individual folds). Only models that include a model-selection step are shown: the classical ensembles with their inner architecture search and the D-MPNN with a nested search over 8 configurations; the default D-MPNN, which has none, is reported in Table 4. Times are not normalized by thread count.